

FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO WORKPLACE
ISOLATION IN REMOTE WORKERS

by

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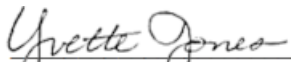
December 2022

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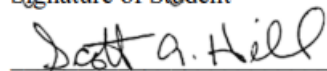
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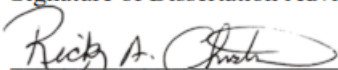
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I first want to give God all the glory, honor, and praise! I know that he is responsible for guiding me through this journey. His grace, mercy, and love were vital to my completion. When I felt like giving up, I felt that push. When I needed the words to flow from my mind to the paper, you helped them flow easily.

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DEDICATION

I dedicate this dissertation to my husband, Will, and my daughters, Ashley and Jordyn. I thank you for your support and unconditional love.

ABSTRACT

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Remote work continues to emerge as an alternative work option. This quantitative correlational study aimed to identify perceptions of workplace isolation among remote workers and factors contributing to it, specifically focusing on supervisory support, communication satisfaction, and the time worked remotely. The researcher surveyed remote workers at least 18 years old and working in the U.S. or U.S territories about their perceptions of these variables. The study's results indicated significant relationships between workplace isolation and supervisory support and between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction. Workplace isolation decreases when supervisory support and communication satisfaction increase. However, the results showed no relationship between workplace isolation and time worked remotely. Identifying the relationships helps meet the needs of these workers.

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CHAPTER I

INTRODUCTION

As more workers electively choose or must work from home, it is essential to understand their needs and provide them with the necessary tools to ensure that they continue to be productive and satisfied (Nakrošienė et al., 2019). Supervisors play a crucial role as they often are the direct link between the employee and the organization (Duffy, 2018). While remote workers may be absent from the building, they should remain a vital part of the organization. This study looked at what employees feel contributes to feeling connected and how they perceive workplace isolation and supervisory support. It also examined the factors contributing to feelings of isolation and disconnect and how an individual's perception of supervisory support and communication satisfaction influence how they perceive workplace isolation. The information obtained is helpful to organizations as they strategically plan how to manage remote workers. It also identified the tools and resources needed to make them feel supported in their new, less traditional work environment.

The problem addressed was remote workers experiencing feelings of social isolation and disconnection from the organization while working in a remote environment. In 2016, the International Data Corporation (IDC) predicted that remote working in the United States would show continuous growth and increase by more than nine million in the timeframe from 2015 to 2020, contributing to the remote worker

population making up more than 72.3% of the entire workforce (Timsal & Awais, 2016). In early 2020 the Coronavirus pandemic came about, and the number of U.S. workers working from home increased substantially. According to Brynjolfsson et al. (2020), about 15% of workers in the U.S. worked remotely before the COVID-19. In April 2020, 49% of U.S. workers worked remotely (Brynjolfsson et al., 2020). The gap in literature requiring further research was that it was unknown why remote workers feel socially isolated and disconnected. Additionally, further explanation was also needed to determine what leaders can do to support these workers. This quantitative study explored the factors that contribute to remote workers feeling socially isolated and disconnected from their organization and what leaders can do to help them feel included and valuable.

There are many benefits to remote working, including shortened travel time, reducing costs for employers and employees, and employee satisfaction (Aczel et al., 2021; Johnston & Shahani, 2020; Moretti et al., 2020). Remote work has its advantages, but it also presents some shortcomings. Employees may have a hard time separating work from family life, spend more time working, and hinder career advancement opportunities (Nolan, 2020). Employees may also feel disconnected from the company's significant decisions and overlooked for promotions (Timsal & Awais, 2016). Leaders may find that they are less likely to motivate remote staff and maintain their trust (Nolan, 2020). How can leaders help this specific group of workers identify these factors and work with them to overcome barriers or factors that contribute to the work at home experience not being as efficient and optimal as intended? Additionally, how can leaders identify when remote workers are struggling or need additional resources to make this specific group of workers feel included? Furthermore, how does leadership support help convey that the

intent is not to make these workers feel left to defend themselves on an island isolated from the entire organization but to help them overcome these feelings (Nakrošienė, et al., 2019).

In a study by Sull et al. (2020), 45% of Human Resources leaders surveyed in April 2020 identified providing the needed technology, computer hardware, software, and office furniture are essential to transitioning to remote working. Whether the organization furnishes these resources or if a stipend is provided for employees to purchase these items on their own, it is an investment that companies should consider when requiring employees to work remotely (Sull et al., 2020). Remote workers can feel neglected because they are not physically in the same location (Aczel et al., 2021). Social support from leaders may help make workers feel connected (Stallard et al., 2020). Leaders can show social support in the face-to-face environment through various platforms such as phone, email, and instant messaging (Golden & Gajendran, 2019). Recently Zoom and other video meeting platforms such as Webex Teams have also offered additional ways to provide social support and provide the necessary modes of communication to keep in touch with employees, helping them feel more connected (Sull et al., 2020).

With the physical disconnection from the actual organization, there will be no conversations in the hallway or informal chats at the water cooler to discuss current events (Burkus, 2021). Being able to catch up with a co-worker in the employee lounge during a lunch break is a thing of the past. The remote work environment limits face-to-face interactions that offer a time for leaders to observe employees' behaviors and employees the chance to socialize with one another (Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018). These interactions provide an opportunity for leaders to assess if workers are operating in a

manner consistent with that of the organization (Howard-Grenville, 2020). By assessing these interactions leaders could identify a need to educate employees on the company's culture and help impress upon the workers those common themes that employees are expected to follow.

Rationale

The thought of being able to roll out of bed and have a zero-mile commute seems intriguing to some. The hustle and bustle of navigating through the traffic, avoiding blocked lanes, accidents, and broken-down vehicles can be daunting (Fried & Hansson, 2013). Potential benefits to remote work include the thought of no stress associated with the morning rush and no instances of road rage are welcomed ideas (Timsal & Awais, 2016). When considering all the factors that go along with getting to work in the morning, many workers would love to trade in that morning ritual for one that is not so rushed and much less hectic (Timsal & Awais, 2016). For some, remote working may offer a great alternative with less chaos. On the other hand, this work option may have some disadvantages associated with the lack of face-to-face interaction with co-workers leading to co-worker isolation and a feeling of disconnect (Sull et al., 2020).

Remote working has been around for decades, dating back to skilled workers working from home in medieval days (Bhargava, 2018). The rationalization for offering American workers the option to work remotely has changed over the years. In the 1970s, this option provided an alternative for working that would eliminate a commute in the wake of a national gas shortage (Gallatin, 2018; Torten et al., 2016). Over the next few decades, its focus changed based on the demands of the times and the workers' preferences. Employers offered remote workers opportunities to work from home on a

full-time basis (Nakrošienė et al., 2019). Other options include working from home a few days, coupled with working at the physical work building on other days (Fried & Hansson, 2013).

Since the beginning of 2020, there has been an increase of remote working due to the COVID-19 pandemic and social distancing requirements (Allen et al., 2021; Pozen & Samuel, 2021). While COVID-19 may have contributed to the rise in remote work, the increased advances in information technology have been an underlying force that has helped push the transition to alternative decentralized work environments (Pozen & Samuel, 2021).

Remote work goes by many names, including telework, work from home, virtual working, and home office (Aczel et al., 2021; Bhargava, 2018; Stallard et al., 2020). The term remote work is defined as a way of working that encourages workers to work outside the traditional office setting (Prasad et al., 2020). This work style can also be described as an alternative work arrangement that allows employees to work outside the traditional office building (Russell & Cates, 2013). Bhargava (2018) explained that the main difference between working from home and remote working is that working from home is temporary and urgent, while remote working is more permanent and consistent.

Hickman (2019) referred to this class of workers as remote workers. Similarly, Lee (2018) and Painter (2017) referenced them as remote employees. In comparison, another study described these workers as teleworkers (Gallatin, 2018). Primarily, these workers work from home a significant amount of time but can connect to the main office using technological advances (Nolan, 2020). In 2018, nearly 75% of workers reported that their company offered a telecommuting option, with 33% having worked in a remote

capacity (Schawbel, 2018). A study from early 2021 revealed that 70% of employees worked remotely at least once a week (Schwartz et al., 2021).

Previous studies have looked at various aspects of remote working and how it impacts workplace engagement, employee stress, and workplace relationships (Gallatin, 2018; Klecha, 2019; Lee, 2018). Another study also explored how remote workers experiencing health concerns such as stress and musculoskeletal issues associated with practicing poor ergonomics and the lack of the proper equipment and office furniture (Moretti et al., 2020). This study took another direction and specifically looked at factors that may contribute to workplace isolation and disconnect. The purpose was to help identify common problems that remote workers may encounter, and the researcher assessed how these workers perceive their feelings of isolation and how the level of their supervisor's support and communication influence these feelings. The researcher looked at the factors that may contribute to remote workers feeling isolated from the workplace, co-workers, and supervisors. Additionally, the researcher explored how supervisors can identify signs of workplace isolation in employees and how they can support these workers.

Isolation

Instances of social isolation can be challenging for people due to their nature of wanting to socialize with others (Jurblum et al., 2020). The less frequent physical contact with others in the organization can lead these workers to feel isolated from others in the workplace and not as connected (Stallard et al., 2020). Interactions with others in an office setting act as a defense against stress, and without those interactions, isolation occurs (Bird, 2019). Many studies have been conducted to compare social isolation to

various aspects, including a study by Orhan et al. (2016) in which the researchers distributed a questionnaire that captured responses that would indicate their perception of workplace isolation, job satisfaction, and turnover intention. In this study, the self-reported survey method was used to gather data regarding each of the variables on one questionnaire initially sent out to 908 potential respondents (Orhan et al., 2016).

In a recent exploratory qualitative study, participants indicated that they wanted interventions that enabled social connections in the workplace (Olsen et al., 2018). Toscano and Zappala (2020) conducted a study to show the correlation between social isolation and productivity in remote workers. While remote working has been around for a while, it is new to many workers. A study by Koren and Pető (2020) revealed that 43 million workers worked in occupations that required face-to-face interactions and communication with other co-workers. Those who are new to working from home may find it challenging to transition to an environment focused on physically interacting with one another to one of little to no physical interaction (Bhargava, 2018).

Effect of Pandemic

Remote work is here to stay (Pelczarski, 2021). While the pandemic created a need for increased telework options, many companies will continue to offer this option post-pandemic (Gerst, 2021; Stallard et al., 2020). In contrast, others plan on welcoming workers back to the office. A study by Pelczarski (2021) indicated that while there has been a recent increase in remote workers, 40% of employers surveyed said they would limit remote work options after the pandemic. The COVID-19 pandemic disrupted many businesses; it not only required companies to think outside the box to create new business models and process changes, but it also pushed many to fast-track to a new way of

working in the future (Schwartz et al., 2021). One lesson learned from the pandemic is that work is not about where you are but what you do (Schwartz, et al., 2021).

The COVID-19 pandemic has forever changed working life across the world (Moretti et al., 2020). Its sudden onset and overwhelming presence impacted individuals' ability to work and organizations' ability to keep their businesses operational (Diab-Bahman & Al-Enzi, 2020). At the time of this study, the pandemic was ongoing, and its full impact not realized. Further research is necessary to understand the experiences of remote workers that were rapidly pushed into remote working positions as a response to the COVID-19 pandemic (Malti, 2020).

Connectedness

Humans are social creatures that need others (Jurblum et al., 2020). Relationships help individuals with commonalities connect. Meaningful relationships are essential unions that involve more than one individual (Witzel, 2018). In work from home settings connecting with others may be difficult; therefore, building relationships could cause ethical concerns due to the lack of person-to-person contact. Often, relationships that begin at work evolve into meaningful relationships that reach outside of the organization's four walls (Allen et al., 2021). There are many means of building strong relationships in an organization. One key to building relationships is to strengthen communication (Citrin & Derosa, 2021). Communication is a leadership tool used in creating relationships between leaders and followers (Brown et al., 2019). The ability to communicate with other like-minded individuals allows the connection with people with similar interests and beliefs, which are two traits that may help to build authentic, meaningful relationships (Northouse, 2019).

As offices shift from physical buildings to virtual spaces workers' mental health and ability to connect with others are impacted (Schwartz et al., 2021). When employees do not feel connected in the workplace, it can negatively impact productivity and cause feelings of isolation (Howatt, 2021). This study examined how employees feel socially connected. To foster an environment that makes everyone feel connected, leaders must establish trust through their actions, including teaching and coaching employees, being flexible through change, treating all employees fairly, and making social connections a strategic priority (Howatt, 2021).

Communication

Communication, technology, and honesty are factors that may be perceived as contributing to perceived support (Nakrošienė et al., 2019). One of the most challenging aspects of remote working is communication (Johnston & Shahani, 2020). As more American workers transition to teleworking, it is essential to consider how the change can be made easier. A recent study suggested that communication is critical to this transition by identifying that regular manager communication to check on employees to see how they are doing effectively prevents them from feeling isolated (Sull et al., 2020).

Communication in virtual environments can be improved by learning to write better, offering clarity, and understanding the etiquette of email and instant messaging (Bhargava, 2018). Communication should be open, honest, and free of conflict (Citrin & Derosa, 2021). A recent study by Hickman (2019) suggested that to improve communication supervisors should meet more frequently with remote workers. Hickman (2019) also recommended creating a prescribed way that remote workers engage with one

another and their supervisors to strengthen communication and improve connectedness. This study examined how communication impacted workplace isolation.

Trust

Honesty helps to build a strong foundation built on trust. Trust must be established between workers and supervisors to ensure support is appropriately provided by leadership (Northouse, 2019). Both leaders and subordinates must follow through to show that they are truthful and uphold their obligations to each other. Examples include meeting deadlines, executing deliverables, and responding to each other in a timely manner (Nakrošienė et al., 2019).

Ethical leaders are highly trustworthy (Sharma et al., 2019). These leaders are honest in their business transactions and interactions with others, therefore setting a positive example for their subordinates. It is crucial that leaders are honest with remote workers. If not, it could negatively impact their relationships (Northouse, 2019).

In recent times, working from home was an option for some but was mandated for others. In times of such uncertainty all around them, employees need their organization's leaders to be open and honest with them, thus building their trust. Employees deserve to know the truth. The amount of transparency and honesty conveyed by leaders will facilitate how subordinates respond to them (Northouse, 2019). In forced remote working situations, it would be beneficial for leaders to be honest with staff about the duration of the work from home assignment, the company's expectations, and future.

Related Theories

There are various theories, such as the social network theory, social exchange theory, and the leader member exchange theory that are relevant to understanding the

relationships that remote workers have with others, including co-workers and their supervisors (Barratt & Smith, 2018; Brown et al., 2019; Chekwa, 2018; Chieh-Peng et al., 2019; Northouse, 2019). The social network theory clarifies how individuals interact with each other and can be applied to help understand how social exchange relationships are developed within work environments, with the knowledge that a lack of these relationships contributes to social isolation (Barratt & Smith, 2018).

The social exchange theory is utilized to help employees have positive relationships. A recent study explored how the social exchange theory helps explain how it impacts the performance of employees working virtually (Chieh-Peng et al., 2019). The study looked at how remote workers gauge their perception of success by what they receive in turn, including incentives (Chieh-Peng et al., 2019).

The Leader Member Exchange (LMX) theory helps process how leaders and subordinates interact (Northouse, 2019). The LMX relationship has an impact on making subordinates feel valued. Leaders should understand this theory and adjust accordingly to ensure their followers are perceiving them as a good leader, and if not, are willing to make necessary adjustments (Brown et al., 2019). In a remote working environment this is essential. Chekwa (2018) discussed how if leaders are not careful, they could cause subordinates to feel left out and not connected to the organization. As organizations strive to include a diverse group of workers, they sometimes unintentionally create a leader member exchange outgroup, causing employees to feel isolated and estranged.

Technology

As companies transition to alternative working arrangements, they are challenged with whether employees are psychologically ready for these changes, not the technology

available (Schwartz et al., 2021). In the remote world, technology is essential to its success (Citrin & Derosa, 2021). The increase in technology has significantly increased the utilization of remote working by allowing remote workers more access and opportunity to be independent outside of the office (How absence can make the heart grow fonder, 2019). An increase in Information Technology has increased the instances of remote working (Marica, 2018). The use of technology allows for greater flexibility for workers. Remote workers often feel disconnected even though they have numerous technological advances at their disposal aimed at keeping them connected (Bhargava, 2018). To avoid feelings of disconnect, remote employers must understand the role of technology and understand that it is a means for collaboration and a way to connect with colleagues (Schawbel, 2018).

Perceived Supervisory Support

As workers migrate home, they are limiting their interactions with others that remain at the office or that may also be working from home. The human link between the organization and the remote worker is their supervisor (Pozen & Samuel, 2021). Remote employees' perception of how supervisors support them could make a difference in how they feel about the job and how they feel the organization includes them and makes the effort to help them feel connected. They can offer social support through other technologies instead of face-to-face interactions (Golden & Gajendran, 2019). As leaders try hard to lead effectively in a remote environment, remote working often allows leadership flaws to become more destructive (Bhargava, 2018). It is crucial that leaders develop trust in a remote environment to ensure workers feel included. Supervisors and other leaders must ensure they share information promptly, show empathy for employees,

set the tone and expectations, show that they trust employees, follow-through, be available, and are consistent in their practices (Bhargava, 2018).

Hickman (2019) suggested that supervisory training and development be considered an integral part of the training regimen for individuals leading remote employees to ensure they are prepared to lead these teams (Hickman, 2019). A qualitative study by Painter (2017) interviewed 10 participants and ask them questions regarding self-efficacy, personal engagement, and relationship with the leader. This study examined how employees perceived leadership support impacts workplace isolation.

Research Questions

The following research questions were used to direct this study:

1. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and supervisory support?
2. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction?
3. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely?

Description of Terms

Remote work. The process of working beyond the traditionally defined office setting (Prasad et al., 2020).

Social connectedness. The perceived connection that individuals feel towards others (Lee & Robbins, 1995).

Supervisory support. Assistance offered to non-supervisory employees by those in supervisory roles including but not limited to feedback on performance, career guidance, and opportunities to enhance employee development and visibility (Greenhaus et al., 1990).

Telework. Working option involving a change in location outside of traditional office, but not a change in the scope of an employee's work

Working from home. Working from a locale outside of the normal work location provided by one's employer (Aczel et al., 2021).

Workplace isolation. The lack of emotional, physical, and psychological connection to one's workplace characterized by one's perception of being disconnected from co-workers and the support of the organization (Marshall et al., 2007; Orhan et al., 2016).

Contribution of the Study

Humans want to be social (Jurblum et al., 2020). Workers feeling socially isolated from co-workers and the organization is typical in the remote working environment (Toscano & Zappala, 2020). This study was instrumental in identifying the factors that contribute to remote workers feeling left out, tactics that leaders can use to support them, and other possible solutions to address this issue. Understanding the impact of working from home is valuable information for leaders in these organizations, employees, families and friends, and co-workers.

Benefit to Stakeholders

As mentioned previously, several stakeholders benefit from this study. A study by Maruyama and Tietze (2012) suggested that both employees and employers will benefit

from telework in numerous ways. These stakeholders include the organizations offering work from home options, the employees working from home, their family and friends, and their co-workers. The benefits gained from this study include helping stakeholders identify when remote workers are feeling isolated, help support them, and allow the opportunity to plan future remote work deployments and mitigate current issues strategically.

The recent surge in working from home has steadily increased between early 2020 to early 2021, which are attributed to social distancing and shelter in place requirement (Moretti et al., 2020). As vaccinations roll out and more people get vaccinated, the prevalence of remote working may be impacted as businesses begin to loosen restrictions and start to reopen. Decisions will need to be made regarding if workers will be asked to come back inhouse or continue to work remotely.

Newly vaccinated American workers longing to get back to having face-to-face interactions may face new challenges for returning to work. Companies that have formerly embraced remote working but saw negative impacts such as poor financial performance, low employee morale, and decreased employee engagement have eliminated or revised remote work policies (Schawbel, 2018). The policies place stricter stipulations on remote working circumstances and revise who is eligible and outline specific circumstances that will require remote workers to come back into the brick-and-mortar building (Schawbel, 2018). Companies such as Reddit, Honeywell, Yahoo, and HP have all revised policies that emphasize remote working is not one size fits all and that physical interaction fosters teamwork and employee engagement (Schawbel, 2018).

This study is helpful to both employees and employers to help determine which option is best for all involved. The results of this study could be used to help employees understand some of the issues associated with remote working and the likelihood of experiencing these issues. It is also essential for early detection of feelings of isolation or disconnect for employees who will continue to work from home. Identifying employees' perceptions of isolation, connectedness, and supervisory support provides leaders with the ammunition they need to be prepared if employees start to experience these things. Additionally, this study can help both employees and employers develop good communication skills that help each effectively communicate their needs, wants, and expectations. The information taken from this study could be used for organizations that employ remote workers by incorporating some items into new employee orientation and other training opportunities.

Contribution to Professional Leadership Practice

This research study was needed because of the increase in remote working and telecommuting. It is essential to understand the importance of identifying when these workers are not adjusting appropriately and may not feel connected to the organization. As the workplace shifts from office to home, one-on-one interactions decrease, making it more challenging to connect physically and emotionally with colleagues (Stallard et al., 2020). Leaders must continue to communicate and connect with remote workers and work on a plan to ensure that they support them and make them feel included. Facebook encourages virtual environments; however, CEO Mark Zuckerberg and COO Sheryl Sandberg consistently meet face-to-face biweekly to ensure that they have the one-on-one interaction they feel is necessary to make them more effective (Schawbel, 2018). The

researcher examined the impact of supervisory support and communication on workplace isolation in remote workers.

Remote work has been around for a long time and is steadily increasing due to various factors such as technological advances, an ease of communication, a disruption of work, and globalization (Bhargava, 2018; Citrin & Derosa, 2021). The widespread practice of remote work accelerated by the COVID-19 pandemic created a need for leaders to learn how to lead remote teams and for employees to adapt to the changes (Citrin & Derosa, 2021). The pandemic affected many industries, and it is projected to be here to stay (Gerst, 2021). Leading remote employees requires leaders to lead differently (Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018). This study contributes to the professional leadership practice by offering a reference for leaders being faced with leading remote employees to identify and mitigate concerns with these workers experiencing workplace isolation. This study raises the awareness of the need to communicate openly and consistently with remote workers, the importance of offering the tools and support for these workers, and how to plan for the continued use of remote work.

Following the lockdown associated with the COVID-19 some companies had to resort to remote working, which offers advantages and disadvantages for the employee and the employer (Prasad et al., 2020). Employers desire remote working as an alternative to continue to get work done when other factors prevent face-to-face interactions. It also offers employees an alternative, flexible work solution that is more cost-effective and convenient (Stallard et al., 2020). This study benefits the employer by giving them recommendations for supporting remote workers. These remote workers can

benefit by their leaders becoming aware of the struggles these workers face and empowering them with the courage to ask for support when needed.

An organization's primary goal is to carry out the objectives of the organization successfully (Burkus, 2021). Doing this may mean gaining maximum profits, obtaining more clients, providing quality care to patients, or delivering excellent customer service. The people of the organization are behind its success. When people are happy, they are more productive and more focused on meeting goals (Baum & Homisak, 2013). Employees want to feel connected to the organization and its culture. Culture connects individuals in an organization and affects their behaviors (Johnson, 2019). It is the leader's responsibility to prepare themselves and their followers for challenges that may arise. Changes associated with adapting to new challenges test leadership (Bolsinger, 2015).

Process to Accomplish

The researcher used a correlational design in this study. The problem that needed to be addressed was that remote workers may experience feelings of workplace isolation while working in a remote environment. Workplace isolation supports the employee's desire to be a part a group of co-workers that focuses on providing support and assistance related to issues and concerns at work (Marshall et al., 2007). Additionally, it is based on how employees perceive how available their peers are to them to offer support at work (Marshall et al., 2007). Further research was needed to examine why remote workers feel isolated and disconnected. This study's purpose was to shed light on remote working and the implications that may come along with this type of work environment, making it useful to remote workers, supervisors, leaders, and potential job seekers when

determining the best fit for a position. Many instruments are used in literature to gather the data necessary to interpret how the variables will impact remote workers. This study utilized several instruments to measure various aspects that influence remote workers and the identified variables.

Research Design

Quantitative research is numerical and analytical and focuses on identifying relationships between variables and understanding them (Simon & Goes, 2018). It involves taking numerical data collected and explaining and predicting a specific occurrence (Mills & Gay, 2019). Compared to qualitative research, quantitative research usually involves a larger sample size, involves minimal participant interaction, utilizes defined instruments to collect measurable data, and involves statistical analysis (Mills & Gay, 2019).

The quantitative correlational design is used in research to determine if two or more variables are related (Mills & Gay, 2019). This study examined the relationships between workplace isolation, supervisory support, communication satisfaction, and the length of time worked remotely. Both qualitative and quantitative research can utilize research questions (Mills & Gay, 2019). Quantitative studies can include research questions or hypotheses to describe the variables (Creswell & Creswell, 2018). In this quantitative study, the researcher chose to examine three specific research questions to help investigate the relationships between the variables.

The study utilized correlational research which is consistent with the correlational design in quantitative research (Mills & Gay, 2019). A correlational study looks at the relationships between variables and can be used in relationship or prediction studies

(Mills & Gay, 2019). This study also used instruments that previous researchers used in numerous studies (Gallatin, 2018; Gipson, 2017; Humel, 2019).

Participants

The population is the broader, much larger group from which the researcher chooses the sample (Mills & Gay, 2019). The targeted population was remote workers in the United States and U.S. territories. The sample size was at least 30 participants, consistent with a quantitative, correlational design study (Mills & Gay, 2019).

Participants participated at will by accepting virtual invitations through professional and personal networks and were not chosen by the researcher. Participants were asked to pass on the invitation to others, utilizing the snowball method (Mills & Gay, 2019).

Instruments

Choosing the most appropriate instrument is essential to capturing responses that are representative of the population. Collecting data is a crucial component of any research (Mills & Gay, 2019). This research used a variety of instruments to collect data related to each of the variables being explored. In all, there were two instruments and one demographic questionnaire used to gather pertinent information. The four individual instruments were consolidated into one survey (see Appendix A).

The instruments included the Workplace Isolation Scale (Marshall et al., 2007), the Supervisory Support Survey (Greenhaus et al., 1990), the Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire (Downs & Hazen, 1977), and a demographic questionnaire. The demographic questionnaire included seven questions that were used to collect basic demographic information that could be analyzed to better describe participants. The

questionnaire was comprised of questions previously used in a study relating to remote workers, as well as some created by the researcher (Gallatin, 2018).

The Workplace Isolation Scale, developed by Marshall et al. (2007), has been used in previous studies regarding remote workers to help determine if they feel isolated at work and from their colleagues. The original scale was comprised of 65 items on a seven-point Likert scale ranging from 1- strongly disagree to 7- strongly agree. The revised scale was reduced to a two-factor model that delineates between company and colleagues and consists of 10 items (Marshall et al., 2007).

The Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire measures the factors contributing to communication satisfaction among respondents (Downs & Hazen, 1977). The Communication Satisfaction Survey is like the questionnaire developed by Roberts and O'Reilly (1974) that measured communication within organizations. However, in the study by Downs and Hazen (1977), they explored how communication satisfaction impacted overall job satisfaction. In developing this instrument, the researchers concluded that communication is multidimensional and provides a way to measure organizational function (Downs & Hazen, 1977). In this study this instrument was crucial in determining how respondents felt about the level of communication received and whether it was satisfactory. This scale is comprised of 40 items on a seven-point Likert scale ranging from 1-very satisfied to 7- very dissatisfied.

The Supervisory Support Survey measured how respondents felt about how much their supervisors supported them (Greenhaus et al., 1990). This survey was created and used in a study that examined how race impacted job performance and career opportunity

advancement (Greenhaus et al., 1990). This scale is comprised of nine items on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 5 - strongly disagree to 1 - strongly agree.

The demographic questionnaire was included to gather information to determine if respondents met the criteria for participation including their age. Additionally, the questionnaire included the respondents' gender, their role at work, length of time worked remotely, and the number of hours per week worked remotely. The information was gathered to help describe respondents while analyzing data (Gallatin, 2018).

Data Collection

The surveys disseminated included the Workplace Isolation Scale (Marshall et al., 2007), the Supervisory Support Survey (Greenhaus et al., 1990), the Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire (Downs & Hazen, 1977), and a demographic questionnaire combined into a single questionnaire sent to individuals through the internet. The distribution of the tool took place by sending it through the researcher's professional and personal networks. An invitation email accompanied the survey, which encouraged respondents to forward the link to others they felt may be qualified and interested in completing the survey.

The practice of sending out a measuring tool and asking participants to forward it to others is consistent with the snowballing sampling method, also called chain referral (Simon & Goes, 2018). The snowball method is a good way to obtain data when participants may have access to others who meet the criteria for the study (Simon & Goes, 2018). The instruments sent out in the survey were part of a one-time administration.

The researcher's minimum sample size was 30, which is consistent with the minimum sample size for quantitative correlational design studies (Mills & Gay, 2019). However, the researcher desired to have at least 100 participants. Participants' responsiveness determined whether the researcher solicited help from a company designed to help distribute the instrument to qualified individuals. Once the desired number of participants had completed the survey in its entirety, the researcher closed the survey. The snowball sampling method captured responses from as many participants as possible.

To answer research question number one, **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and supervisory support**, the Workplace Isolation Scale measured respondents' feelings towards workplace isolation, how they felt being a part of their organization, and their relationship with co-workers and supervisors (Marshall et al., 2007). The Supervisory Support Survey measured supervisory support and how respondents felt their supervisors supported them.

To answer research question number two, **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction**, the Workplace Isolation Scale measured respondents' feelings towards workplace isolation, how they felt being a part of their organization, and their relationship with co-workers and supervisors (Marshall et al., 2007). The Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire measured communication satisfaction and how respondents felt they were provided adequate communication.

Research question number three was, **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely**, the Workplace Isolation Scale measured respondents' feelings towards workplace isolation, how they felt being a

part of their organization, and their relationship with co-workers and supervisors (Marshall et al., 2007). Question six on the demographic questionnaire measured the length of time respondents worked remotely.

Data Analysis

Interpreting the data involved reporting the information regarding the number of participants that attempted the survey and how many completed it in its entirety. Secondly, the researcher determined if there had been any response bias based on responses. A descriptive analysis for all independent and dependent variables was performed, followed by running the Cronbach alpha test to determine the internal consistency of the scales (Creswell & Creswell, 2018). Finally, the results were displayed using graphs, tables, and/or figures.

Quantitative data are numerical. It requires statistical analysis to analyze the data collected. The first research question was, **what was the relationship between supervisory support and workplace isolation?** The researcher correlated workplace isolation and supervisory support. The data for workplace isolation were collected from the Workplace Isolation Scale, which is a seven-point, multi-question Likert scale. The data for supervisory support were collected from the Supervisory Support Scale, which is five-point, multi-question Likert scale. The data were retrieved, organized, and prepared for analysis. After preparation, the researcher transformed the individual items into two scores, a score that reflects each of the two constructs. The Pearson r correlation test was utilized as the analytical test for this question.

The second research question was, **what was the relationship between communication satisfaction and workplace isolation?** This research question is

correlational. The researcher correlated communication satisfaction and workplace isolation. The data for workplace isolation were collected from the Workplace Isolation Scale, which is a seven-point, multi-question Likert scale. The data for the communication satisfaction were collected from the Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire, which is a seven-point, multi-question Likert Scale. The data were retrieved, organized, and prepared for analysis. After preparation, the researcher transformed the individual items into two scores, a score that reflects each of the two constructs. The Pearson r correlation test was utilized as the analytical test for this question.

The third research question was, **what was the relationship between the length of time worked remotely and workplace isolation?** This research question is correlational. The researcher correlated workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely. The data for workplace isolation were collected from the Workplace Isolation Scale, which is a seven-point, multi-question Likert scale. The data for length of time working remotely were collected from question number six on the demographic questionnaire. The data were retrieved, organized, and prepared for analysis. After preparation, the researcher transformed the individual items into two scores, a score that reflects each of the two constructs. The Pearson r correlation test was utilized as the analytical test for this question.

Conclusion

The rise in remote work brought on by changes in the workplace due to technology, trends in the modern workplace, and mandatory requirements due to COVID-19, makes it crucial to understand its impact on remote workers. It is crucial for

both employees and supervisors to understand how workplace isolation, social connectedness, supervisory support, perceived organizational support, and communication satisfaction are related. The knowledge and understanding of these factors will help build cohesive remote teams composed of happy employees (Pozen & Samuel, 2021).

CHAPTER II

REVIEW OF LITERATURE

Introduction

The workplace has changed over the last 30 years (Barratt & Smith, 2018). The nature of work has transitioned from a traditional work environment to one that is more flexible and virtual, with employees feeling freer to work in the space that best fits their needs (Chernyak-Hai & Rabenu, 2018). Remote working is an option for employees to work from a location outside of the main office, offering a safe work environment away from potential exposure to health issues while offering flexibility, in return for satisfied employees that are more productive (Bell, 2019). While trying to provide these benefits to employees, organizations must understand the need for employees to connect with their colleagues. Connections with others are necessary because they naturally desire to want relationships (Wocial, 2018). This study will be helpful to remote workers, their supervisors, and leaders in the organizations that employ them. Potential job seekers may also find this information helpful when searching and determining the job that is their best fit.

This study's purpose was to shed light on remote working and the implications that may come along with this type of work environment. The information gathered and the results will help workers in the various fields and industries that employ remote workers. Additionally, this study contributes to academia by discussing remote workers and identifying their feelings of workplace isolation and communication satisfaction

while offering supervisors and leaders an opportunity to understand how they can support these employees and prevent these feelings.

This literature review thoroughly assesses previous works that helped define the problem and identify stakeholders, common themes, theoretical approaches, and historical relevance. The study helps lay the research framework through the researcher's ability to identify, locate, and analyze the literature relating to the identified research problem (Mills & Gay, 2019). The researcher used various tools and strategies to provide a thorough and well-developed literature review of the remote working phenomena, the history of the problem, and the factors contributing to its utilization while associating it with the concepts addressed in the research questions (Mills & Gay, 2019).

One should consider many aspects when allowing staff to work from home to avoid the transition negatively impacting the organization. The disruption to regular operations could be devastating. The impact could wreak havoc on employee morale, productivity, and the culture. Preparing staff and offering solid support is essential to move from onsite work to remote work successfully. The literature review conducted by the researcher outlined a historical basis for the concepts of the study by connecting each one to various theories and previous research. The specific concepts addressed include remote work, workplace isolation, supervisory support, communication satisfaction. Additionally, the study provided a great discussion of the cultural perspective of remote work.

The following research questions directed this review of literature and study.

1. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and supervisory support?

2. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction?
3. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely?

Literature Review Strategy

To obtain relevant information related to the historical overview and other material about the specified area of interest, the researcher conducted a literature review, a prescribed process of identifying, finding, and analyzing the information (Mills & Gay, 2019). The purpose of the literature review includes the ability to look at what has already been done regarding topics similar to the current researcher's problem and allows an assessment of whether those methods and processes related to data collection approaches and strategies were successful (Mills & Gay, 2019).

The researcher researched specific areas related to the study to provide a complete collection of literary works that contributed to this study. The researcher used several tools, resources, and methods to collect information relating to each area of interest. The databases and search engines used included but were not limited to ProQuest Central, ProQuest Ebook Central, Academic Search Ultimate, All EBSCO databases, Google Scholar, Google, Gale Academic OneFile, Trevecca Nazarene University Wagoneer Library Discovery Searching, and Trevecca Nazarene University A-Z Databases.

To ensure the relevance of pertinent data for each area, the researcher concentrated on the most current literature. Most of the references date back to 2016 or are more up to date. However, some sources may be older if they relate to historical information. The researcher used both recent and older literature to ensure a thorough

representation of the literature representing current literature themes. Older literature helps understand foundational references to the topics related to this study.

To make a literature review more productive and easier to navigate, one can use keywords for the search. Selecting the right keywords significantly influences the success of one's search for literature (Mills & Gay, 2019). The reviews were conducted by searching for keywords or phrases related to the various aspects of the study. These keywords included telecommute, COVID-19, Coronavirus, and communication. The key phrases searched included remote working, remote work, remote workers, telecommuting, telecommuters, flexible work arrangement, work from home, team, dispersed team. Other terms included workplace isolation, isolation, social isolation, social connectedness, supervisory support, communication satisfaction, manager traits, leader traits, social network theory, social exchange theory, workplace isolation scale, supervisory support scale, communication satisfaction questionnaire, and social distancing.

To ensure the integrity of the sources used, the researcher concentrated on sources considered scholarly sources. Scholarly sources include sources written for academic publications such as academic journals and exclude non-reliable sources such as internet sources, blogs, trade journals, and magazines (Mills & Gay, 2019). The scholarly sources used included peer-reviewed academic journals, previous dissertations and theses, government publications, textbooks, and published books.

Historical Overview of Remote Work

Working is a part of life that many people must endure. While there are multiple types of jobs, there are also various work environments. Remote work involves working from a location outside of the traditional office (Jude & Kumar, 2016; Thulin et al.,

2019). Remote work goes by many names, including telework, working from home, and telecommuting (de Klerk et al., 2021; Golden & Gajendran, 2019; Thulin et al., 2019).

A couple of events marked the beginning of the remote work phenomenon. It began around the 1970s to help workers deal with the oil crisis, enabling an individual's inability to commute to work due to the gas shortage (Torten et al., 2016). Another event of the 1970s that was instrumental in the development of remote working was in 1973 when Jack Nilles published *The Telecommunications-Transportation Tradeoff* (Burkus, 2021). He discussed how the transportation crisis was reduced by creating many satellite offices across the city to prevent traffic congestion (Burkus, 2021). This event would be a precursor to the remote working environment of today. Nilles invented the term *telework* (Burkus, 2021).

The remote working trend continued to grow in the 1980s. In 1989, Charles Handy thought the telephone would revolutionize the decrease of large, centralized offices (Burkus, 2021). In 1993 remote working decreased, despite thoughts from management guru Peter Drucker, that workers continuing to commute to the office was ending (Burkus, 2021). Moving into the 2000s technology increased, primarily in larger tech firms, however by the mid-2000s remote work decreased as companies such as Yahoo, IBM, and Best Buy began coercing workers back into the office by creating enticing perks to lure them back in (Burkus, 2021).

In 2018, in the United States, only about three percent of the population worked remotely, almost half of their working hours (Burkus, 2021). As remote work steadily decreased an unexpected virus, COVID-19 helped foster its resurgence. Because of the transmissibility of this virus, organizations needed to create an alternative work option

that would allow the business to continue while still helping minimize transmission by sending employees home to work. Companies had to adjust and adjust fast. For example, during the first wave of COVID, IBM reported that more than half of its employees primarily worked remotely (Burkus, 2021).

Remote work is an alternative to the traditional working environment (Niu et al., 2021; Rysavy & Michalak, 2020). This work option has been utilized consistently for years (Niu et al., 2021; Torten et al., 2016). It has been around for decades but has seen a significant increase over the past few years. Since 2005, employees working remotely or telecommuting have increased by 140 percent, growing ten times faster than the remainder of the workforce (Wang et al., 2020).

Working remotely away from the office should not make workers feel alone on an island. This option offers many benefits, including less traffic, more independence, flexibility, and reduced occurrences of health risks associated with the job (Niu et al., 2021). In contrast, there are also some disadvantages, such as no distinction between work and life and working more intense hours (Niu et al., 2021). Workers and their leaders must decide if remote work is the best choice that offers employees the best opportunity to perform at their optimal level (Nolan, 2020).

Increasing technology has made it possible to operate outside the main facility (Mininni & Manulti, 2020). For many years before COVID-19, organizations were moving towards more remote work utilization to reduce costs, attract more diverse talent, and prepare for globalization (Citrin & Derosa, 2021). A spike in remote work utilization during the COVID-19 pandemic created an urgency to implement, allowing organizations to remain afloat amid the world's shutdown to slow its spread (Diab-Bahman & Al-Enzi,

2020; Langovska & Rozentale, 2021). On March 11, 2020, the World Health Organization declared COVID-19 a global pandemic, almost immediately creating the need for individuals to work from home as shelter in place orders were issued to slow the spread of the disease (Paiuc, 2021).

The COVID-19 pandemic has heightened the trend to work remotely (de Klerk et al., 2021). One thing about this emergency push was that it was universal and impacted many industries and professions (Citrin & Derosa, 2021). The pandemic immensely changed working life, as it has been known (Moretti et al., 2020). Before the pandemic working in a remote environment was done occasionally as a convenient option for workers (de Klerk et al., 2021). As the pandemic stretched globally, the need for remote work became more of a necessity as workers were forced home due to lockdowns across the world (de Klerk et al., 2021).

COVID19 accelerated the widespread implementation of working from home on a more global level (Niu et al., 2021). While the need to shelter in place and social distance creates an immediate need to make this transition, it showed that this option could work with some learning curves (Niu et al., 2021). Previous studies have examined the factors influencing remote workers' experiences transitioning to remote work (Langovska & Rozentale, 2021; Torten et al., 2016).

The COVID-19 pandemic created an emergency need for organizations to make drastic and immediate changes (Diab-Bahman & Al-Enzi, 2020; Niu et al., 2021). Now that companies know that remote working is a feasible option to traditional work environments, it will surely be a choice for both employers and employees for years to come (Niu et al., 2021). The COVID-19 pandemic has contributed to the increase in this

work option (Diab-Bahman & Al-Enzi, 2020; Howard-Grenville, 2020; Mininni & Manulti, 2020; Niu et al., 2021; Toscano & Zappala, 2020).

The increase in technology and the most recent rise in utilization have helped realize what works and what does not. The contemporary teleworking models involve spreading the phenomenon to new groups, a different view of working hours, and greater accessibility through advanced technology and digitalization (Thulin et al., 2019). The percentage of Americans working remotely was 49% in April 2020 (Brynjolfsson et al., 2020). This statistic is a significant increase compared to the 24% noted in early 2018 (Golden & Gajendran, 2019).

Opportunities and Challenges of Remote Work

Remote work offers many advantages and disadvantages. Advantages include no commute, flexibility, and the ability to utilize new technology (Bird, 2019; de Klerk et al., 2021; Marica, 2018; Olsen et al., 2018; Nakrošienė et al., 2019; Wang et al., 2020). Studies have also shown that remote work has been shown to be more efficient, as seen by greater productivity among workers (Nakrošienė et al., 2019). An individual with high uncertainty avoidance prefers planning and predictability, while a person with low uncertainty avoidance prefers flexibility and quickly adapts (Livermore, 2015). The U.S. commonly leads with low uncertainty avoidance (Livermore, 2015). This fact means that the United States emphasizes flexibility and allows its employees to adapt as things happen (Livermore, 2015). Remote workers have their share of advantages. One advantage of remote work is that it offers flexibility (de Klerk et al., 2021). The U.S. commonly leads with low uncertainty avoidance (Livermore, 2015). This fact means that the United States emphasizes flexibility and allows its employees to adapt as things

happen (Livermore, 2015). Low uncertainty avoidance in remote workers may also be advantageous because they have higher adaptability (Livermore, 2015).

Another advantage of remote work is increased productivity (Nakrošienė et al., 2019). The being vs. doing dimension is relative to working and productivity (Livermore, 2015). While some cultures are traditionally more laid back, others may be more task-oriented and focused on working. For example, the Americans and other Anglo cultures place a lot of emphasis on doing (Livermore, 2015). An individual that is "being" enjoys life, while a doing individual focuses on keeping busy and meeting objectives (Livermore, 2015). An individual's level of being or doing could impact productivity. Previous studies have examined productivity among remote workers (Toscano & Zappala, 2020). In a remote working environment, an individual high in being may get sidetracked and not be as productive. While a person is identifying as high in doing work hard to get things done and efficiently utilize their time, possibly resulting in higher productivity.

The success of remote working has proven to be a viable opportunity for companies to cut costs while allowing employees a flexible option (Bird, 2019). In remote working, as environmental, physical, and operational systems change, so will the impact on these stakeholders (Torten et al., 2016). The context of work and work relationships are steadily evolving with the variety of work options, causing multiple implications to these relationships (Cooper-Thomas & Morrison, 2018). The remote working structure contributes to how workers interact with their supervisors and coworkers and is instrumental in their perceptions of their relationships with others (Gallatin, 2018). Social exchange, leader-member exchange (LMX), and social network

are relevant theories when discussing relationships between remote workers, their supervisors, and the individuals on their team. These theories discussed in this study help explain how leaders and followers interact and how these relationships impact work in the remote working environment.

One challenge of remote work is the ability to balance work and life (Nakrošienė et al., 2019; Marica, 2018). The monochronic and polychronic cultural dimensions deal with time. Monochronic emphasizes tracking time by keeping work and personal time separate, while polychronic combines times through multitasking. This dimension relates to whether an individual has a work-life balance or not (Livermore, 2015). Working in a remote setting can sometimes blur the lines between work and life balance. Monochronic individuals delineate between the two from a cultural perspective, while polychronic individuals make themselves available (Livermore, 2015).

Another challenge of remote working is being able to function in a team virtually (Jude, 2017; Orhan et al., 2016). A team is a group of individuals working together harmoniously to achieve identified objectives (Kupa, 2020). Organizations are made up of internal and external stakeholders. The stakeholders previously identified are both internal and external. Often stakeholders work together to achieve success for an organization, with their roles within the team being different but essential. Quality interaction between the group members contributes to great teams (McGuire, 2018). There are various types of teams. The major types of teams include co-located teams where everyone is at the same location, completely remote teams where the team is disbursed throughout multiple locations but are working towards the same objectives, and hybrid teams where some employees spend some time working together at one location

and others work from other locations (Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018). Remote workers may find it more challenging to collaborate and network in a virtual environment than their coworkers working in the office (Rysavy & Michalak, 2020).

A range of factors contributes to an effective team, including roles and responsibilities, performance and performance rewards, communication, and team-building functions (Rayner, 2020). Virtual teams are a relatively new phenomenon that has made a more significant occurrence due to the emergence of digital transformation (Kupa, 2020). This transformation brought about changes in technology in communication and information (Kupa, 2020). It allows team members to work together in separate locations, creating a more flexible and diverse team with greater access to each other (Jude, 2017; Kupa, 2020). For any team to be effective, it must have a foundation based on trust, accountability, and commitment (Lencioni, 2002; Northouse, 2019).

Virtual teams in remote environments provide a variety of challenges contributing to their failure (Burkus, 2021). Often the challenges are associated with dysfunction within the group. Lencioni (2002) outlines why teams fail in his *Five Dysfunctions of a Team*. One way to overcome the dysfunctions of a team is for the team members to learn to understand each other. Lencioni (2002) described the five dysfunctions of a team as the absence of trust, fear of conflict, lack of commitment, avoidance of accountability, and inattention to results. Numerous studies have explored team dysfunction (McGuire, 2018; Sterling, 2020).

Building trust is the first step of building a successful team (Burkus, 2021; Lencioni, 2002). Whether in a remote or traditional work setting, trust within a group

often feels unattainable (Burkus, 2021). Building trust can be extremely challenging, especially in a virtual team (Citrin & Derosa, 2021). This idea may be difficult in remote teams because of the lack of face-to-face interactions (Chekwa, 2018; Koren & Pető, 2020; Malti, 2020).

Lukic and Vracar (2018) conducted a study that examined the role and priority of trust in a remote setting. In another study that surveyed over 600 remote workers, 81% indicated that when there is trust among the team members and their leader, the process is smoother (Burkus, 2021). It can be more challenging to do this remotely than in a traditional office setting (Brewer, 2015). Lencioni (2002) describes the first dysfunction of a team as the absence of trust. Trust is often associated with high-performing and effective teams (Es-Saijade & Wilkins, 2017). Many teams do not thrive because trust has not been established (Burkus, 2021; Lencioni, 2002).

Individuals can overcome dysfunction by improving their emotional intelligence (EQ). Emotional intelligence is essential for leaders to understand how workers feel and react to an environment that lacks physical interaction. An individual's EQ could impact how they think about being alone. One study collected data from 469 respondents via an online survey composed of the Myers Briggs Company High Performing Team model questionnaire and the Fundamental Interpersonal Relations Orientation (FIRO) business tool questionnaire, measuring their expressed and wanted behaviors compared to organizational goals (Rayner, 2020; The Myers Briggs Company, 2018). The study looked at personality variations among managers of various workgroups and found no personality differences, but that remote team managers scored higher in emotional intelligence (Rayner, 2020).

Remote teams are different from non-remote teams, and it requires specific guidelines that will help the team be successful (Diab-Bahman & Al-Enzi, 2020; Marica, 2018; Zhong et al., 2021). Initially, teams are trying to find common ground and set the team's standards. Leaders must set ground rules in a virtual team to avoid misunderstandings that could contribute to failure. Burkus (2021) outlines standard rules that remote leaders must establish to ensure success. The regulations include encouraging a shared understanding, developing a shared identity, and formulating a shared purpose for the team (Burkus, 2021).

Cultural influences are another challenge of remote work (Barratt & Smith, 2018; Kupa, 2020; Reis, 2016). The population for this study was remote workers aged eighteen years old and older working in the United States or U.S. Territories. Participation in this study was open to individuals in the U.S. territories. While they may have a similar culture to other U.S. states, those individuals may have significant cultural differences. For example, the U.S. and Puerto Rico share legal similarities, but culturally they are distinct (Fok et al., 2016). While this study did not include participants outside of the United States, there was still a cultural aspect comprised of the organizational cultural differences represented by the differences in the organizations they worked.

The demographic characteristics of remote workers may influence their cultural perspectives. Managers working in remote environments face possible issues of managing workers remotely. The problems include handling conflict and communicating effectively, calling for cross-cultural management expertise (Reis, 2016). One way to capture specific data that may indicate an individual's culture is to create demographic information from participants. Based on their answers to demographic questions,

researchers can take the information and analyze it to make assessments gained from the data. Demographics and cultural dimensions are assessed based on demographic questions participants answered.

This literature review outlines the cultural factors influencing remote workers' behaviors, their perception of workplace isolation, and their feelings of supervisory support. Characteristics of the identified culture guide their cultural responses. Not all countries within a culture will have the same views on working. Different cultures will have different perspectives of what is expected (Chattopadhyay, 2019). Culture is those things a group shares, such as shared beliefs, values, and traditions, that shape the group's behavior (Burkus, 2021; Livermore, 2015). It is unique and transmittable to others within the group (Northouse, 2019). According to Livermore (2015), three distinct types of culture include national, ethnic culture, and organizational culture. All three types of culture may impact remote workers and how they interact with others, their perspective of support, and their preferred communication styles and expectations. Organizational culture is most relevant to this study and understanding its impact on remote workers.

A person's native land is an everyday basis for their national culture. National culture shapes the ideas of what one identifies as being, their influences, and how they react and behave around others (Livermore, 2015). Livermore (2015) describes it as being unconscious but more inherent because it is the culture that shapes us. For example, an American studying abroad may closely identify with other American foreign exchange students based on their national culture and commonalities in their beliefs, traditions, and customs. This type of culture is often associated with a group's country of origin (Livermore, 2015). An individual's national culture could influence one's views on

interacting with others. Physical interactions are often replaced with virtual interactions (Nakrošienė et al., 2019). One's national culture impacts these interactions.

Ethnic culture is the culture associated with a specific ethnic group or ethnicity (Livermore, 2015). Ethnic culture delineates how specific nationalities feel and behave even if they are a part of a bigger and broader national culture. For example, African Americans and Caucasians in the United States have different cultural perspectives. African American cultures and traditions often are noticeably different or in contrast from their white counterparts (Livermore, 2015). A few examples include religious beliefs, practices, food choices, etc. The concept of ethnic culture is valid in the United States and some other countries where diverse ethnic groups reside within a country or nation but may be less prevalent in other countries where their national culture dominates (Livermore, 2015).

Many individuals make up an organization. They all have their personalities, their own set of core values, and personal beliefs. However, when working for a company, employees must adopt the values and views of the organization (Howard-Grenville, 2020). A team's culture greatly influences its success, and from a virtual team perspective, culture is a fundamental part of creating a culture conducive to its flourishing (Burkus, 2021). The lack of encouraging shared visions within a remote working environment could raise ethical issues regarding the difficulty of disseminating consistent information to all employees across multiple locations (Ruiller et al., 2019).

Organizational culture is a common type of culture leaders are most concerned with as it is the culture that a specific organization creates and maintains (Livermore, 2015). Corporate culture shapes the group's behaviors and attitudes within the

organization's context. While organizations are composed of diverse individuals of various national and ethnic cultures, their organizational culture is unique to and tailored around their organization (Livermore, 2015; Orlowski, 2016). In the remote environment, organizational cultural influence could significantly impact how connected and engaged these workers are.

An example is an employee who works for a healthcare company moving from working with one healthcare system to another. There may be specific rules and regulations that are regulatory requirements for the healthcare industry. However, each organization's culture shapes the mission, values, and policies. The best way to teach culture is through experiences on the job (Davis et al., 2016).

In the job selection process, both the employee and the employer must consider the organization's culture to determine the union will work due to a good fit between both parties. Because culture is created and not necessarily something that arbitrarily happens, it can be beneficial to select a candidate with some characteristics that may be consistent with the organizational culture in hopes of full adoption by the individual as they grow with the company (Livermore, 2015). Often organizational cultural issues can lead to job and employee satisfaction, and ultimately turnover (Kupa, 2020).

In the traditional office setting, the organizational culture happens through shared interactions (Burkus, 2021). Similarly, it becomes more apparent to a worker if they identify with the organizational culture since there are more opportunities for interactions that indicate the characteristics of the culture and help the employee align with the organization's culture (Stallard et al., 2020). It may be more challenging to determine in a

remote setting due to employees' displacement away from the main office. Hence, the importance of being connected to the culture in different ways.

This study contributes to the literature relating to dimensions of culture that apply to individuals working in a remote environment. Culture can be viewed by looking at various dimensions and theories. Researchers have created different ways of understanding culture among groups and conceptualizing culture. Hofstede looked at culture by developing his cultural dimensions: uncertainty avoidance, power distance, institutional collectivism, in-group collectivism, gender egalitarianism, assertiveness, future orientation, performance orientation, and humane orientation (Northouse, 2019). Hofstede collected over 100,000 respondents from over 50 countries (Northouse, 2019).

The cultural value dimensions described by Livermore are similar to those expressed by Hofstede. These cultural value dimensions include individualism vs. collectivism, power distance (low and high), uncertainty avoidance (low and high), cooperative vs. competitive, short term vs. long term, low and high context (direct vs. indirect), being vs. doing, universalism vs. particularism, neutral vs. affective, and monochronic vs. polychronic (Livermore, 2015).

The most notable cultural study performed in history is the Global Leadership and Organizational Behavior Effectiveness (GLOBE) (Northouse, 2019). This comprehensive study looked at people's behaviors in 62 countries to identify differences in leadership based on similarities and differences among the groups (Northouse, 2019). The ranking and the study resulted in a hierarchy of various countries into cultural clusters that indicate common behaviors and characteristics of the people in the groups (Livermore, 2015).

The ten clusters of world cultures include Anglo, Germanic Europe, Latin Europe, Sub-Saharan Africa, Eastern Europe, Middle East, Confucian Asia, Southern Asia, Latin America, and Nordic Europe (Northouse, 2019). The study helped link specific cultural dimensions to a cultural cluster. This literature review highlights particular dimensions of culture that apply to individuals working in a remote environment.

Building a culture of trust and connectedness in a remote working environment is a significant challenge (Choudhury et al., 2020). This literature review looks at culture from a broader perspective. Cultural implications can arise based on the culture within specific regions or the territory, similar to distinctions such as Northern and Southern perspectives. This review examines remote working practices in other countries to understand differences and similarities to issues identified in the United States. This study explicitly analyzes remote employees' perceptions in the United States or U.S. territories.

Previous studies examined remote workers in countries like Mexico, Africa, Italy, and Lithuania (Cernas-Ortiz & Wai-Kwan, 2021; Malti, 2020; Nakrošienė et al., 2019; Toscano & Zappala, 2020). The cultural dimensions associated with each culture could impact their views on working remotely. The culture may also affect how they behave and adapt to this particular work environment. Like the United States, the workforce in other countries is experiencing an upward shift in remote working. For example, in Sweden, a large portion of the workers are working remotely (Thulin et al., 2019).

The remote working trend has increased recently due to the COVID 19 pandemic and social distancing requirement (Moretti et al., 2020). Remote work goes by many names, including telework, work from home, and virtual working (Aczel et al., 2021).

The global impact of the pandemic impacted a diverse group of people. This sudden need for remote work has reached many countries and includes many cultures. Culture influences how individuals work, including working hours, operating locations, age requirements, and who is eligible to work (Johnson, 2019).

It is vital to understand cross-cultural differences and how they impact decision-making and work ethics, leading to a more cohesive work environment (Fok et al., 2016). The increase in globalization means that companies are venturing out, requiring not only an interdependence between nations but a need to understand better cultural influences (Mittal & Elias, 2016). Based on the current demand, it is vital to understand how culture impacts how workers deal with the difference in the work environment, determining their confidence level, which could influence their perception of connectedness, especially in a remote environment (Choudhury et al., 2020).

Workplace Isolation

The increase to more remote working has been positive for most (Citrin & Derosa, 2021). While there are benefits, remote work has negative drawbacks (Citrin & Derosa, 2021). Workplace isolation is feeling isolated from others while working (Marshall et al., 2007). It could result from the working environment, the individual's personality, or other dynamics at work (Marshall et al., 2007). One of the main contributors to workplace isolation is the distance (Chekwa, 2018). Working in a remote environment offers less physical interaction, creating less opportunity for these workers to interact, causing more instances of isolation (Chekwa, 2018). It can affect leaders as well as followers. Employees benefit from talking to and bouncing ideas off coworkers (Schawbel, 2018).

On the other hand, leading at a distance can be lonely as well (Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018).

Working remotely can be lonely, and remote workers may feel disconnected from their team (Burkus, 2021). In a recent study, 64 percent of individuals surveyed answered that their connections with coworkers were negatively impacted by remote working (Citrin & Derosa, 2021). Additionally, the COVID-19 pandemic contributed to these feelings of isolation. Marshall et al. (2007) created the Workplace Isolation Scale to measure a worker's perception of feeling isolated at work by answering questions that will portray their level of feeling included or feeling isolated. The tool measured two dimensions of workplace isolation: the individual's perceptions of isolation on a social status by their feelings of isolation from their coworkers and on the organizational level by their feelings of the organization's support network.

The employees surveyed worked in a variety of industries. The scale comprises ten items assessing employees' perceptions of isolation based on a seven-point Likert Scale (Marshall et al., 2007). The scale reads one strongly disagree, two disagree, three somewhat disagree, four neither agree nor disagree, five somewhat agree, six agree, and seven strongly agree (Marshall et al., 2007). Then ten items are divided into two subscales, one about colleague support and five related to company support (Bell, 2019).

Their study sought to gather information to develop a tool to use in future studies to assess the two elements of workplace isolation, isolation from others at work and isolation from the company's support network (Marshall et al., 2007). It also identified how an employee's level of workplace isolation is directly attributed to not being

recognized or shown support from supervisors, the lack of interactions between colleagues, and not feeling included as part of the group (Marshall et al., 2007).

Collectivism and individualism focus on whether an individual places more emphasis on the goals of the group or their personal goals (Livermore, 2015). The Anglo culture has a high individualist rating (Northouse, 2019). Individuals high in collectivism are not concerned with receiving individual recognition for their contributions but desire to do what is in the group's best interest (Northouse, 2019). From an organizational perspective of a remote working situation, a person may tend to navigate towards being an individualist since they are working from home with no physical interaction with others in the organization. Livermore (2015) describes that an employee of the month program may cater towards an individualist because it recognizes their personal achievements. At the same time, a collectivist may not want that distinction because it celebrates them as an individual and not a group (Livermore, 2015). A similar recognition program may motivate them to perform at their highest potential while working independently (Northouse, 2019). On the other hand, an employee working at an organization that values collectivism may prefer less individual recognition. High collectivist individuals also practice higher interdependence (Golden & Gajendran, 2019).

An individual's level of either individualism or collectivism influences their ability to build relationships. Building meaningful relationships are essential unions that involve more than one individual (Witzel, 2018). This study explored the cultural implications of building relationships, how individuals form relationships, and how those relationships impact their feelings of isolation.

Supervisory Support

Supervisory support is the level of support workers perceive received from their supervisors (Schawbel, 2018). Employees want to feel supported by their superiors (Schawbel, 2018; Winarto & Chalidyanto, 2020). The support shows them that they can trust their leaders (Northouse, 2019). Leaders must support their employees (Schawbel, 2018). To better understand how supervisors can support their employees, one must first understand the role of a supervisor. There is a difference between leadership and management (Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018; Northouse, 2019). The significant difference is that individuals in management, such as supervisors, focus on things, while leadership focuses on people (Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018).

Numerous studies examined the impact of supervisory support on various aspects relating to employees, including their work engagement, productivity, and retention (Alsaleem, 2017; Yang et al., 2018). A solid level of support from one's supervisor increases the benefits and reduces the negative impact of working from home while improving employee retention (Choi, 2020). The amount of physical, face-to-face interactions directly influences the amount of support received in the workplace (Marshall et al., 2007). Remote workers are at a greater possibility of workers experiencing changes in levels of supervisory support (Chekwa, 2018).

Greenhaus et al. (1990) developed the Supervisory Support Scale to measure how workers feel supported by their supervisor and the amount of supervisory support they receive in their specific job. The amount of interest the supervisor shows in the employee, the resources made available to them, and the amount and type of feedback the employee receives from their leader contribute to the support perceived. Supervisory support can be

categorized into specific areas, including guidance regarding one's career, feedback on their job performance, how they are supported with their work assignments, and opportunities available to them at work (Fields, 2013).

This measurement scale has been proven to be both reliable and valid, with a coefficient alpha of .0.93 and a positive correlation with various perceptions related to satisfaction and acceptance (Fields, 2013). In a study by Winarto and Chalidyanto (2020) they looked at how supervisory support impacted employees and their satisfaction with their jobs, finding that there was a strong correlation between perceived supervisory support and the level of employee satisfaction. In a remote environment, virtual support presents more of a challenge. Remote supervision can be complex, but it is possible (Burkus, 2021; Citrin & Derosa, 2021; Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018; Pozen & Samuel, 2021).

Nine items make up the Supervisory Support Scale. The items help identify how individuals feel about how they perceive the degree of career support their immediate supervisors provide (Greenhaus et al., 1990). It is a five-point Likert scale with one strongly agree, two agree to some extent, three uncertain, four disagree to some extent, five strongly disagree (Greenhaus et al., 1990).

Power distance measures the amount of equality or inequality experienced by a particular group (Hofstede, 2011). According to Hofstede (2011), power is measured by how followers identify and accept that the level of authority between them is not equal. On a broader range, it relates to how societies have different acceptance levels that inequality exists, but the issue is understanding the extent (Hofstede, 2011). Low power

distance emphasizes leaders and followers sharing decision making, while high power distance emphasizes leaders making all decisions (Livermore, 2015).

The perception of supervisory support could be affected by the power distance noticed. Power distance is the distance between a leader and follower (Livermore, 2015). The United States is typically considered to have a low power distance, meaning that it promotes equality and wants followers to share in making decisions (Livermore, 2015). In a remote working environment, power distance is crucial in determining the relationship between leader and follower and building a certain level of trust.

The leader-member exchange (LMX) theory is a leadership theory focused on the relationship between the leader and the follower, emphasizing the interactions between the two (Dansereau et al., 1975; Northouse, 2019). In their study, Dansereau et al. (1975) focused on distinguishing between supervision and leadership, in which supervision relies mainly on the actual employment contract. In this exchange, the employee received agreed-upon compensation for them following the prescribed duties of the job (Dansereau et al., 1975). In comparison, the leadership aspect focused more on creating other ways to influence the desired behavior of the employee, such as assigning additional responsibilities, decision-making capability, and opportunities for skill development in exchange for an increased commitment to meeting the organization's objectives (Dansereau et al., 1975).

The LMX theory looks at the interactions between the leader and each follower rather than a collective group of followers (Northouse, 2019). In their study Dansereau et al. (1975) concluded that a superior could have a supervision relationship with some employees while also having a leadership relationship with other employees. Building

stronger relationships between the leader and follower is an advantage of utilizing the LMX theory (Northouse, 2019). A high-quality leader exchange is excellent for the individuals with this high-exchange relationship but could cause envy among other group members with a low-quality exchange (Yang et al., 2018).

The perceived favor of the high-quality exchange group over the low-quality exchange group could lead to the preferred group ostracizing the other group (Yang et al., 2018). In a remote working environment, this is crucial in making employees feel personal and supported by their supervisors (Chekwa, 2018). Various studies have looked at how these relationships impact aspects such as employee engagement, job satisfaction, and relationships between coworkers (Chekwa, 2018; Yang et al., 2018). Often the objective is to look at the outcomes of the leader-member exchange (Northouse, 2019).

Because individuals working in alternative work environments, such as remote working, are distanced from their leader, contributing to a low-quality exchange (Chekwa, 2018). The LMX theory creates an "in-group," comprised of individuals within the team that have a strong relationship with the leader, and the "outgroup" made of those individuals that do not have a strong relationship with the leader (Chekwa, 2018; Northouse, 2019; Yang et al., 2018). The distance experienced in remote working could cause these workers to be less interactive with the supervisor, making them part of the "outgroup" (Chekwa, 2018).

Organizations that have employees working remotely and in-house within the organization may prefer the in-house workers. Because the in-house workers are physically in the exact location of the supervisor, they may have a stronger relationship, leading to a higher quality exchange (Yang et al., 2018). The increased interactions could

lead to this group being labeled as the "in-group," while the remote workers being the outgroup. The old saying, out of sight, out of mind, applies to remote workers who are not given as much in terms of resources and the leader's time due to being physically separated (Yang et al., 2018). The limited interactions could lead to animosity and ostracism (Yang et al., 2018). A possible result is workplace isolation.

Another theory directly impacting supervisory support is the social exchange theory (Choi et al., 2019). George Homans (1958) developed the social exchange theory, which says that human behavior is a give and take between people involving exchanging goods for behavior. Blau (1986) further explains the social exchange theory (SET) as human behaviors being considered exchanges of resources between the individuals involved, often referred to as actors.

This theory influences the LMX because the number of social interactions between supervisors and subordinates contributes to the quality and strength of the leader-member relationship (Chekwa, 2018). The social exchange theory is the foundation of other theories, such as the social network theory (Barratt & Smith, 2018). It says that a series of relationships that involve give and take between the individuals involved make up life (Akar & Dalgic, 2018; Barratt & Smith, 2018). People need interaction and this theory helps explain why and to what extent (Choi, 2020).

The Social Exchange Theory suggests that the number of social exchanges between the leaders and followers within an organization and among a team is crucial (Chekwa, 2018). One of the significant barriers to social exchange is differences in geographical location and other factors such as technology, time zones, and the

department's size (Chekwa, 2018). Chernyak-Hai and Rabenu (2018) examined how changes to this theory influenced new changes in the modern workplace characteristics.

A great example is a rise in the work from home option that many organizations are adopting. Chieh-Peng Lin et al. (2019) examined how various social aspects directly influence virtual team performance. In their study, the researchers surveyed leaders and team members. They determined a correlation between social exchange and social cognitive theories in comprehending how virtual teams operate, contributing to their success or failure (Chieh-Peng Lin et al., 2019). In a study by Yoshikawa et al. (2018), they examined how generalized social exchange is relevant in the new era or workplace relationships.

Communication Satisfaction

Effective communication is essential for any leader (Burkus, 2021; Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018). Communication conveys the goals, expectations, and assignments individuals are responsible for carrying out. Communication involves talking about getting something done and includes the action needed to get the job done (Burkus, 2021). In a remote working environment, it is vital that the technology used to aid in communicating is up to par and is sophisticated enough to support what is needed to carry out the team's objectives (Burkus, 2021).

It is crucial that the right mix of tools are selected to effectively communicate within a team (Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018). Choosing right involves knowing the various types of communication, the team's dynamic, and the organization's timeline and objectives (Burkus, 2021). Since communication goes both ways, the communication avenues must apply to supervisors and employees. In the remote team, it is crucial that

the team successfully communicate through various means. While face-to-face interactions are less frequent or non-existent other technologies to promote communication are essential (Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018). However, organizations may benefit from occasional face-to-face interactions to build trust among the team (Citrin & Derosa, 2021).

The Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire (CSQ) developed by Downs and Hazen (1977) measures how satisfied employees are with the level of satisfaction they receive. This instrument classifies communication satisfaction into eight distinctive groups: organizational integration, organizational perspective, media quality, horizontal communication, personal feedback, supervisory communication, subordinate communication, and communication climate (Downs & Hazen, 1977). Previous studies used the CSQ to assess organizational communication's impact on stakeholders, perception of leader efficiency, and staff's communication satisfaction based on the organization's communication practices (Hamel, 2019; Sharma et al., 2019).

Low context (direct) and high context (indirect) emphasize communication (Livermore, 2015). Low context (direct) emphasizes using one's words to communicate, while high context (indirect) emphasizes indirect communication demonstrated by one's tone and body language (Livermore, 2015). Communication satisfaction was one of the theoretical constructs examined in this study. One of the most significant conflict areas among diverse teams is whether the communication is direct or indirect (Livermore, 2015). One of the most challenging aspects of remote working is communication (Johnston & Shahani, 2020). Communication is a leadership tool used to create relationships between leaders and followers (Brown et al., 2019).

Our society is a series of networks dependent on each other and interconnected (Barratt & Smith, 2018). This theory looks at human behavior on a more significant level, based on an individual's relationships with others and how those interactions influence the individual's behavior (Barratt & Smith, 2018). Chernyak-Hai and Rabenu (2018) conducted a study that aided in understanding how technological and other advances have contributed to changes in workplace relationships and how one can adapt social exchange theories to adjust to these changes.

It looked at social exchange as workplace relationships having a solid foundation built on complex networks (Barratt & Smith, 2018). This thought process is what makes up the social network theory. In the era of social media, there are many social networks that individuals can belong. For instance, individuals can connect to or join groups based on similar likes within a social media platform. These groups help them feel connected to each other (Akar & Dalgic, 2018; Barratt & Smith, 2018). In a dispersed or remote working environment, this theory could help explain how these employees may feel isolated due to their distance within their network of people.

Length of Time Worked Remotely

Time on a job shows commitment and dedication to the organization. However, one's time at a job could influence how one feels about the job's various aspects, depending on the amount of time they have worked there (Caillier, 2017). This thought process applies to all work environments, including remote work. The amount of time spent working remotely contributes to feelings of disconnection and isolation from colleagues, influencing their perception of workplace isolation (Gipson, 2017).

In this study, the information needed to collect the data regarding the length of time worked remotely was measured by including a demographic questionnaire question asking how long you have *worked remotely*? New employees are prone to turnover if they are not satisfied with their job (Gao et al., 2019). The advantages outweigh the disadvantages of the remote environment contributing to lower turnover (Gao et al., 2019).

Often employees that have left a job indicate job satisfaction as the reason for leaving (Gao et al., 2019). For remote workers, turnover is lower than other work arrangements (Gao et al., 2019). While many factors are contributing to job satisfaction, enjoying the work environment is a top contender (Choi, 2020). Remote workers often find value in the convenience of working from home, such as no commute, greater flexibility, and the use of more advanced technology (Choi, 2020). This convenience attributes to their desire to want to continue to work remotely.

IBM conducted a survey of their remote workers amid the COVID -19 pandemic in which 75 percent of those workers indicated that they wanted to continue this option as their primary work assignment (Burkus, 2021). Similarly, companies such as Facebook, Citigroup, and Shopify have all made the permanent shift to total or partial work from home options for employees since the pandemic showed the possibilities and benefits of remote working for both the organizations and employees (Burkus, 2021).

Stakeholders

Stakeholders in research are the individual voluntary or involuntary risk-takers that have some stake in the study's success (Huemann et al., 2016). This study's primary internal stakeholders are the remote workers, the supervisors overseeing these workers,

and the organization (Diab-Bahman & Al-Enzi, 2020; Niu et al., 2021). These internal stakeholders are directly impacted by remote work, whether the actual workers or the individuals managing them. The external stakeholders are their friends, families, and the individuals they serve (Hiswals et al., 2020). These individuals are not directly impacted but are indirectly affected by their relationship with the remote workers (Hiswals et al., 2020).

The impact on stakeholders changes with the times. In the early years of remote working, a flexible work alternative for a specific group of employees who wanted to work outside of the office to accommodate better their lifestyle (Choudhury et al., 2020; Diab-Bahman & Al-Enzi, 2020; Rymaniak et al., 2021). The decision to work at home was often at the employee's request (Bird, 2019). Enthusiasm and positive attitudes resulted from choosing, resulting in higher morale, acceptance of the process, accountability, and compliance (Kaplan et al., 2018).

As technology became more advanced, many companies had the means to offer a remote work location (Niu et al., 2021). Also contributing to the rise in teleworking options was the push for organizations to provide a flexible work environment (Torten et al., 2016). Additionally, the COVID-19 pandemic contributed to the impact that remote working had on these stakeholders (Mininni & Manulti, 2020).

The first wave of the COVID- 19 pandemic created a sudden need to quickly implement a new group of coworkers by force rather than choice (Mininni & Manulti, 2020). At that time, remote working was supposed to be a temporary fix in response to an unexpected situation (Burkus, 2021). The number of remote workers has exponentially increased since the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic (Agba et al., 2021). The new

normal is the term for this sudden migration to remote work because of the sudden increase and the continuation by many organizations (Agba et al., 2021). Keeping that in mind, organizations are adjusting to this new way of working (Agba et al., 2021).

Internal Stakeholders

Remote workers are the primary internal stakeholders in working from home. Remote working can be difficult for the employees (Rysavy & Michalak, 2020). They directly feel the emotional impact of being displaced from the brick-and-mortar building, their team, and the organization's culture (Nakrošienė et al., 2019; Wheatley, 2021).

Remote workers experienced changes to their work environment, work habits, and relationships with non-remote coworkers (Niu et al., 2021). They have some issues not shared by their cohorts working in the office, including isolation, exclusion from various activities, and disconnect from the organization (Rysavy & Michalak, 2020). While supervisory support and communication are essential in making employees feel included, employees must also do things to feel connected to their coworkers and supervisors. Rysavy and Michalak (2020) suggest that remote workers use social media sites such as Twitter and LinkedIn to keep in touch with others within the organization.

Smart working is synonymous with remote work (Mininni & Manulti, 2020). Because of a forced push to remote work during COVID-19, many workers made the transition quickly (Mininni & Manulti, 2020). The concept of Smart Working is that remote workers can autonomously manage work and home life while working beyond the traditional work environment (Mininni & Manulti, 2020).

Supervisors

Teams rely on great managers to make them great (McGuire, 2018). Managing remote workers can be challenging (Jude, 2017). Supervisors and managers must set clear expectations from the beginning for a remote working situation to be most effective for the employee (Rysavy & Michalak, 2020). Clear expectations establish boundaries early, leading to a clear understanding and open communication essential for working remotely (Rysavy & Michalak, 2020).

Remote workers want to feel included and supported. Most employees acknowledge that much of their dissatisfaction with their job stems from their supervisor (Burke, 2017). Supervisors are vital to providing support for remote workers. Leadership roles in a virtual team are somewhat different from those in a traditional work setting (Burkus, 2021; Jude, 2017).

Supervisory leadership is one of the vital leadership types, with remote workers operating in virtual teams (Jude, 2017). This type of leadership focuses on providing the daily monitoring and directing of the group as they work towards the desired vision (Jude, 2017). This type of leadership is similar to managing. The biggest worries of most leaders who lead teams remotely are deciding if they can lead groups in dispersed locations, getting appropriate feedback from staff when needed, determining if employees can interact appropriately socially, and determining if employees are productive (Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018). Because face-to-face interactions are not as frequent, it is vital for supervisors working with virtual teams to offer good communication, collaboration, and supervisory support (Jude & Kumar, 2016).

Supervisory development involves mastering the competencies needed to manage people. Often personality traits influence the ability to manage others (CPP, 2009).

Lencioni (2002) suggested that it is a good idea for those in leadership or supervisory roles to assess their personality traits to determine how they will impact their ability to function effectively as a team member. To help support employees, supervisors must understand them (Northouse, 2019). One way to do that is to improve their emotional intelligence (Northouse, 2019). A solid emotional intelligence involves understanding and identifying their emotions and employees (Northouse, 2019).

Other factors also influence the effectiveness of this group of stakeholders, including personality characteristics and trust. In a study by Rayner (2020), personality differences among supervisors of various teams, including virtual, were examined. The study further revealed that the managers of the virtual teams built on trust experienced higher levels of team success (Rayner, 2020). Supervisors can help support remote workers through trust-building (Nakrošienė et al., 2019). A strategy for improving confidence in a team is for supervisors to effectively deliver positive feedback (Understanding the Currency of Trust, 2020).

A common deficiency of many leaders preventing them from leading to their full potential is how they deal with their followers (Burke, 2017). Different leaders have different styles (Northouse, 2019). Individuals managing others must be conscious of how their inadequacies affect the team (Nappi, 2019). For remote workers, their supervisor must be able to lead them effectively.

Many aspects contribute to a supervisor's leadership effectiveness (Nappi, 2019). Most think of an effective leader as someone with positive attributes (Burke, 2017;

McIntosh & Rima, 2007). However, a dark side of leadership exists (McIntosh & Rima, 2007). Often that dark side leads to a toxic environment that breeds negativity, poor job performance, and psychological issues (McIntosh & Rima, 2007).

The employee's responsibility is to learn the information, ask questions for clarification, be committed, and be open to the process (Northouse, 2019). To facilitate these skills and develop the team, the leader can create training specific to transitioning and maintaining working remotely. It would also be helpful to schedule at least quarterly opportunities for the entire staff to discuss the things happening within the organization and socialize with each other (Johnston & Shahani, 2020). Both the leader and the employee must understand how the process will work in a remote working environment. The leader is responsible for ensuring that the employee has been adequately trained, has the necessary tools and resources needed to perform the job, has outlined the expectations, and is available to support in any way needed (Kupa, 2020; Lukic & Vracar, 2018).

The digital transformation helped change how organizations operate and make remote working more popular (Kupa, 2020). Remote workers contribute to the overall organization by meeting its goals (Torten et al., 2016). Their contribution is part of the strategic plan of the organization. A study by Nappi (2019) looked at the impact team engagement had on the organization's success. A common pitfall of remote working is isolation (Rysavy & Michalak, 2020). Many attribute loneliness and isolation to the individual; however, it is an organizational issue (Hadley & Mortensen, 2021). Supervisors should be innovative in building cohesive teams, including using virtual tools and services such as Zoom or similar platforms (Rysavy & Michalak, 2020).

If remote working is considered a feasible alternative, the organization must have a strategic plan to accommodate and enable remote workers to succeed (Bird, 2019; Kupa, 2020). The COVID-19 pandemic has clarified the importance of being prepared in advance (Rysavy & Michalak, 2020; Sull et al., 2020). Rysavy and Michalak (2020) reported how being prepared by previous communication tools and technology helped them seamlessly transition to an emergency work from home (WFH) within five business days.

External Stakeholders

Remote workers are part of an organizational family, however, often with a significant impact on their own family by their decision to work remotely (Eddleston et al., 2017, 2017; Nolan, 2020). Remote workers spend a lot of time working. Studies have shown that many remote workers have experienced devoting more time to working, often blurring the line between personal time and work time (Carillo et al., 2020; Donnelly & Johns, 2020; Nolan, 2020; Wheatley, 2017,2021).

Medforth (2016) described how technology could keep remote workers in touch with the organization while being physically away from the building and dispersed worldwide. However, this same technology could be a barrier keeping them from spending quality time with their family and friends (Thulin et al., 2019). This same technology is like an electronic leash that makes these employees accessible, even outside working hours.

While technology is convenient, it can be detrimental to remote workers feeling connected and obligated to answer, even when not on the clock (Thulin et al., 2019; Yang et al., 2018). This behavior could lead to emotional and physical burnout, leading to

stress, low morale, decreased productivity, resentment, and poor performance (Moretti et al., 2020; Rymaniak et al., 2021). Ultimately negatively affecting the team and organization.

Remote workers transcend various industries, including healthcare, retail, education, and social service (Allen et al., 2021). The external stakeholders associated with these industries can go by patients, clients, customers, consumers, and students and often impact the services provided to this group of external stakeholders. The professionalism these workers convey directly affects and is reflected by the training and support provided (Lapierre et al., 2015).

The workers' attitudes and behaviors demonstrated by the workers impact the stakeholders. Behavioral deficiencies, a lack of communication, and a lack of supervisory support can affect behaviors towards the individuals they serve, creating a bad attitude or disregarding their time and well-being (Nakrošienė et al., 2019). Supervisory development involves mastering the competencies needed to manage people. One of the characteristics of an efficient supervisor is to identify with one's emotions and others (Johnson, 2019). Poor customer service, sub-par care, and no concern for their welfare can result from less-than-optimal work conditions or lack of support.

Theoretical Foundation

The success of remote working has proven to be a viable opportunity for companies to cut costs while allowing employees a flexible option (Bird, 2019). In remote working, as environmental, physical, and operational systems change, so will the impact on these stakeholders (Torten et al., 2016). The context of work and work relationships are steadily evolving with the variety of work options, causing multiple

implications to these relationships (Cooper-Thomas & Morrison, 2018). The remote working structure contributes to how workers interact with their supervisors and coworkers and is instrumental in their perceptions of their relationships with others (Gallatin, 2018). Social exchange, leader-member exchange (LMX), and social network are relevant theories when discussing relationships between remote workers, their supervisors, and the individuals on their team. These theories discussed in this study help explain how leaders and followers interact and how these relationships impact work in the remote working environment.

Both the social exchange theory and leader-member exchange theory significantly impact supervisory support. For instance, the social exchange theory focuses on people's relationships with each other and how it influences how they work together (Choi et al., 2019). With distance and location being a significant barrier in remote work, it is vital to understand how it impacts workers in dispersed locations and their job performance (Chieh-Peng Lin et al., 2019).

Since its introduction, the leader-member exchange theory has evolved (Northouse, 2019). The initial studies looked at LMX from the origin of the relationships between the groups created within the organization; later studies focus more on how the relationships between the leader and followers impact how effectively the organization operates (Northouse, 2019). Establishing a solid relationship between leader and follower in a remote environment is crucial in the perception of supervisory support (Choi, 2020). The social network theory relies on the need for groups of people to feel connected (Akar & Dalgic, 2018; Barratt & Smith, 2018). Communication is the key to connecting the individuals in the group.

Conclusion

This literature review created a knowledge base that allows for understanding common issues remote workers face. It provided a historical overview of remote work and how it started as an alternative work environment used conveniently. The explanation offered outlined cultural components that illustrated the connection between cultural outlooks and remote workers' behaviors and attitudes, the theories associated with this type of work environment, and the affected stakeholders. This study provides several benefits from a theoretical approach, including understanding how remote workers feel about the type of relationship between them and their supervisors. It also analyzes how it relates to the social exchange theory, the social leader-member exchange (LMX) theory, and the social network theory. As more workers take advantage of work-from-home options, it is essential to understand how it affects their lives. Because remote working will be around for many years to come, leaders must understand the concepts of this study to help them survive leading remotely (Burkus, 2021).

Chapter three will provide an overview of the research methodology to include a description of the research design, a deeper review of participants involved, data collection techniques utilized, and the analytical methods used to compile and analyze the data. This quantitative study examined the perceptions of adult remote workers in the U.S. and its territories. Responses were collected utilizing a single instrument containing a demographic questionnaire (Gallatin, 2018), the Workplace Isolation Scale (Marshall et al., 2007), the Supervisory (Greenhaus et al., 1990) Support Survey, and the Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire (Downs & Hazen, 1977). The findings obtained from this research will further add to the area of study in these domains.

Chapter III

METHODOLOGY

Introduction

Remote working is, also known as telecommuting, working virtually, telework, and working from home (Aczel et al., 2021; Kupa, 2020; Marica, 2018; Nolan, 2020; Thulin et al., 2019), is an alternative work solution that is gaining popularity among many organizations (Timsal & Awais, 2016). As organizations look to improve productivity, increase revenue, and improve employee morale, they should consider various solutions, such as allowing flexibility in work schedules and environments (Choi, 2020; Griffin et al., 2020; Olsen et al., 2018). Studies have shown that remote work offers many benefits, such as elimination of commuting, increased employee satisfaction, and improved productivity (Aczel et al., 2021; Diab-Bahman & Al-Enzi, 2020; Marica, 2018).

While there have been numerous studies regarding remote working and improved productivity and satisfaction, the literature review revealed little research on the factors contributing to workplace isolation. Research regarding remote work, communication satisfaction, and supervisory support are limited. Many previous studies focus primarily on a qualitative research design (Jude, 2017; Nolan, 2020). This study will examine the relationships between workplace isolation, supervisory support, and communication satisfaction to bring it to the attention of employers and potential remote workers so that they can mitigate any potential issues related to these variables and relationships. This

chapter summarizes the research design, describes the study's participants, analyzes the methods used to collect data, and outlines the analytical methodology used to analyze the data. The questions below were the research questions used to guide this study:

1. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and supervisory support?
2. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction?
3. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely?

Research Design

The issues that remote workers encounter are the basis of this study, which analyzes how often they occur when working in an alternative work environment. The researcher applied a quantitative correlational design to answer each of the study's three research questions. There are different analytical methods in research, including quantitative, qualitative, and mixed methods (Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Mills & Gay, 2019; Roberts & Hyatt, 2019). A key determinant in choosing the best option requires understanding each method's techniques and steps (Roberts & Hyatt, 2019).

Researchers use quantitative research when wanting to discover specific factual reasons impacting variables manipulated in a controlled setting (Roberts & Hyatt, 2019). Quantitative analysis uses numerical and statistical data obtained from surveys, experiments, and other data extraction processes (Roberts & Hyatt, 2019). Researchers often use the correlational design to examine the relationships between two variables or theoretical constructs (Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Simon & Goes, 2018). Research using

surveys for data collection provides quantitative or numerical data to show specific trends or attitudes related to the targeted population (Creswell & Creswell, 2018).

This research design often involves collecting data using particular tools or instruments that align with what the researcher is trying to find out (Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Mills & Gay, 2019). The researcher must check the instrument for validity to determine that the information collected was what it was supposed to gather (Mills & Gay, 2019).

Participants

Population

This population of remote workers at least 18 years old and living in the United States or U.S. territories was the focus of this study. The primary stakeholders in this study were remote workers. Based on a study by Brynjolfsson et al. (2020), remote workers make up 49% of the U.S. workforce. The population was all remote workers. As the work industry shifts and this population becomes more prevalent, organizations must consider employees' physical and emotional states. Feelings of social disconnect and isolation are often associated with remote work (Gipson, 2017; Griffin et al., 2020). Since remote work crosses into many industries, it is vital to capture their perceptions.

The target population is remote workers from various backgrounds. The researcher chose this population because it represents the group that will provide the necessary data to determine if the relationships between the identified variables exist. When assessing relationships between workplace isolation, supervisory support, communication satisfaction, and the length of time having worked remotely, it is important to consider individuals who have worked in remote workers' capacity.

Therefore, the researchers narrowed the pool of participants to individuals who worked as remote workers for any amount of time.

The researcher chose the workgroup that specifically worked remotely in the United States or its territories to categorize the results to reflect a specific group of individuals with similar cultural characteristics. However, the researcher did not narrow the remote workers by a particular industry to increase possible responses. The survey was open to remote workers in any field. However, the participants' characteristics narrowed the search to limit the study to remote workers working in the United States or U.S. territories.

Remote workers work some percentage of their time away in a location away from the office. This location can be at their home or any place they choose outside the office. Because the environment is considered remote, the employee often works alone and away from other employees. Previous studies have shown that this may cause them to feel disconnected or isolated (Chekwa, 2018; Gallatin, 2018; Hickman, 2019; Orhan et al., 2016; Wang et al., 2020). This study will provide additional information to identify when remote workers display these feelings and the specific factors contributing to those feelings.

Sampling Plan

According to Mills and Gay (2019), for a quantitative design study, the minimum number of participants required to demonstrate validity is at least 30. In research, obtaining data is essential, but it is equally vital how many people you receive it from (Simon & Goes, 2018). The sample size should represent the larger population (Simon & Goes, 2018). Keeping this in mind, the researcher chose to collect more than the

minimum requirement of at least a minimum of 30 participants. The researcher chose a larger sample size to ensure more accurate results and yield greater statistical power (Simon & Goes, 2018).

Participants

The target population for this study was remote workers at least 18 years old, working in the United States or U.S. territories. The participants voluntarily decided to participate in the study. The researcher set specific parameters to capture participants that best fit the population that the researcher wanted to examine. Desired participants were identified as remote workers at least eighteen years old, working in the United States or U.S. territories. The researcher set the criteria for participants as being at least 18 years old, working remotely at any time, and working within the United States or any U.S. territory.

The total number of respondents that responded was 229. The survey solicited participants by sending out invitations to participate in the study via email and social media sites, including Facebook and Linked In. Participants were ensured that their responses would be confidential. The consent for participation also explained that they have specific rights and provided contact information for the Institutional Review Board (IRB) (See Appendix A).

The participants came from various backgrounds and industries. The study showed that out of 229 responses, 22 identified as male (10.38%), 190 identified as female (89.62%), and 17 did not answer the question. The results indicated that 212 (98.60%) respondents worked in the United States or U.S. territories, 3 (1.40%) did not, and 14 did not answer the question. The results showed that 215 respondents identified as

18 years old or older, and 14 did not answer the question. Specific ages ranged from 21 years old to 78 years old. Out of the 213 respondents indicating their age, the largest group was in their 40's between the ages of 40-49 (35%).

The survey asked respondents to identify their role with the company as either supervisory or non-supervisory. The results indicated that 81 (37.85%) were in supervisory positions, 133 (62.15%) were in a non-supervisory role, and 15 did not answer the question. The researcher wanted to determine if COVID-19 affected the remote working status of respondents. The questionnaire asked if remote working started due to the pandemic, 150 (70.42%) answered yes, 63 (29.58%) answered no, and 16 did not answer the question.

Respondents needed to indicate if they intended to return to work in the office 105 (49.07%) said yes, 109 (50.93%) answered no, and 15 did not answer the question. Responses to the length of time worked remotely included varied, with 215 respondents answering the question and 14 did not. Regarding the number of hours worked per week, 215 responded to the question, and 14 did not. The responses ranged from zero hours to more than 60.

Instrumentation

Instrumentation helps assess participants' perceptions and performance and can pose a potential threat to validity if it is proven to be unreliable (Mills & Gay, 2019). Instruments are the vehicles for collecting data and measuring the relationships between the variables listed in the research questions (Mills & Gay, 2019). Choosing the suitable instruments to collect the appropriate data is crucial. This study utilized a quantitative research design method to collect numerical data. The survey consisted of consent for

participation, a demographic questionnaire, the workplace isolation scale, the supervisory support scale, and the communication satisfaction questionnaire compiled into one document (see Appendix A).

The demographic questionnaire was composed of seven questions and asked questions to gain additional information about the respondents. This information helped categorize the responses. This demographic questionnaire asked questions regarding the respondent's gender, role within the company, pre-COVID remote working status, intention to return to the office, age, the length of time worked remotely, and the number of hours per week worked remotely.

Research question one was **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and supervisory support?** To measure research question one, the researcher used the workplace isolation scale (WIS) to measure how an employee feels isolated at work (Marshall et al., 2007). For this study, the researcher used the revised scale comprised of 10 questions that use a Likert scale ranging from 1-strongly disagree to 7-strongly and distinguishes between company and colleagues. The researcher obtained permission to use the workplace isolation scale from Dr. Greg Marshall and Dr. Jay Mulki on September 3, 2021 (see Appendix B). The researcher also used the supervisory support scale (SSS) to measure employees' perception of the level of support their supervisors provide (Greenhaus et al., 1990). This scale has nine questions that use a Likert scale that ranges from 5-strongly disagree to 1-strongly agree. The researcher obtained permission to use the supervisory support scale from Dr. Jeffrey Greenhaus on September 3, 2021 (see Appendix B).

Research question two was **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction?** In addition to using the workplace isolation scale (WIS) to measure workplace isolation, the researcher also used the communication satisfaction questionnaire (CSQ) to gather data regarding factors contributing to feeling a satisfactory level of communication (Downs & Hazen, 1977). This instrument has 40 questions utilizing a seven-point Likert scale ranging from 1- very satisfied to 7- very satisfied. The researcher obtained written permission to use the communication satisfaction questionnaire by Dr. Michael Hazen on September 3, 2021 (see Appendix B).

Research question three was **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely?** In addition to using the workplace isolation scale (WIS) to measure workplace isolation, the researcher also used a question from the demographic questionnaire. The question asked about the length of time worked remotely. The researcher used a similar question to that from a study by Gallatin (2018). In Gallatin (2018), participants answered a multiple-choice question that asked the length of time as a teleworker. In this study, participants answered a fill-in-the-blank question requesting the length of time they worked remotely. The researcher used other questions from the demographic questionnaire from the Gallatin (2018) study. Multiple attempts were made to obtain permission from the researcher but were unsuccessful (see Appendix B). The researcher, Yvette Jones, could not get permission to use questions from the demographic questionnaire created by Kimberly Gallatin. The researcher Googled Kimberly Gallatin and reached out to Kimberly A. Gallatin-McCombs on Facebook and

LinkedIn. She also reached out to Kim Gallatin on LinkedIn. However, there was no reply.

Several forms of questioning were utilized, including fill-in-the-blank, multiple-choice, and open-ended questions. There are advantages to using all of these types of questions. For instance, open-ended questions allow the researcher to get unforeseen answers that accurately represent respondents' views (Simon & Goes, 2018). On the other hand, closed-ended questions help researchers interpret results more reliably (Simon & Goes, 2018).

The study also utilized Likert scales in the instruments chosen. Likert scales allow respondents to answer questions on a scale based on their personal experience, then rate them based on points assigned to each response (Mills & Gay, 2019). Likert scales are a type of attitude scale that measures perception, views, attitudes, and beliefs (Mills & Gay, 2019). Likert scales display "several ordinal-level categories ranked along a continuum to measure participants' viewpoints" (Simon & Goes, 2018, p.338). It can range in the number of items included, which designates the scale's number of points. These scales have a negative side, a positive side, and a neutral area.

Data Collection

Data collection began after the researcher applied for and received approval to proceed with research from the Institutional Review Board (IRB). The researcher collected the data from a survey created and administered using Survey Monkey, a survey application tool that allows participants to complete it online (Simon & Goes, 2018). The survey combined a demographic questionnaire and three instruments to explore the

variables of workplace isolation, supervisory support, communication satisfaction, and length of time worked remotely.

The breakdown of questions from the survey associated with each instrument and the variable it investigated are as follows. Questions 2 through 10 were the demographic questionnaire, which included a question regarding the length of time worked remotely. Questions 11-20 investigated was the *Workplace Isolation Scale* which explored workplace isolation. Questions 21-29 were the *Supervisory Support Scale* which examined supervisory support. Questions 30-69 were a part of the *Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire*, which investigated communication satisfaction.

The survey opened on December 11, 2021 and closed on January 16, 2022. The researcher chose this specific time because it was during the Christmas holidays. The researcher felt that many people would be taking time off for the holidays and may have extra time to take the survey. Additionally, this was an optimal time for the researcher with more time available to focus on data collection. The distribution of the questionnaire to potential participants occurred on social media. An invitation accompanied the link to the survey. To maximize the potential to receive more responses, the researcher made posts on group pages dedicated to special interests such as academia and education. The social media platforms utilized included Facebook, Facebook Messenger, and LinkedIn. After each initial post to these social media platforms, the researcher reposted it two weeks after the first post.

For this study, the researcher created a consent form with the intent to be completed before a participant could take the actual survey (see Appendix A). The consent consisted of one question. A parameter was set not to allow participants to begin

answering questions unless they agreed to the consent first. Once the participant read and consented to participate in the survey, it opened, and the participant could finish it.

After creating the survey, the researcher sent out invitations to potential participants via social media and email on December 11, 2021. The invitation included an explanation of its purpose and intent. It also had a disclaimer that the information collected would be kept confidential. The researcher created a post that could be copied and shared on Facebook, LinkedIn, Messenger, and email. The post included the introductory explanation statement and the link to the survey. If interested, the participant could click the link that would take them directly to the consent portion of the survey. Once consented, the participant was able to begin.

The researcher utilized an online survey tool to collect data. The survey was self-administered, using the Survey Monkey online tool to create and disseminate the survey to the identified population. Survey information happened once. Data collection occurred during the survey's open times, between December 11, 2021, to January 16, 2022. The researcher sent the invitation to potential participants to their email and social media inboxes and posted the link to various Facebook and LinkedIn group pages. To obtain additional responses, in addition to the initial post, the researcher also reposted two more times during the time the survey was open.

The researcher utilized the snowballing method to increase the number of participants from eligible contacts of previous participants (Simon & Goes, 2018). This method involves sending out the tool to potential participants identified as part of the targeted population and encouraging those participants to forward the link to the survey to other individuals that meet the specified criteria (Simon & Goes, 2018). Using groups

within social media based on similar interests may have been advantageous because the individuals in the group could possess similar characteristics (Simon & Goes, 2018).

Research comes with some risk to reliability and validity. Reliability is the consistent ability of an instrument to yield the same results if used multiple times in the same manner (Roberts & Hyatt, 2019; Simon & Goes, 2018). Validity refers to an instrument measuring what it is supposed to measure (Roberts & Hyatt, 2019). Attrition is an internal validity threat. There was a threat of potential candidates not choosing to participate. This study minimized this threat by explaining to potential participants that they need to complete the survey completely before submitting their responses. An external validity threat to this study was time constraints because participants may have felt that they did not have enough time to complete the survey because it was long and had multiple sections. To mitigate this risk the researcher explained in the invitation that it would take about twelve minutes to complete the survey. By informing participants in advance, it allows them to plan accordingly so that they dedicate enough time to complete the survey. The instruments used in this study were previously used in other studies and have been proven to be reliable.

Analytical Methods

The analysis of the data occurred after data collection. Data analysis involves describing the specific methods used to analyze the data received during the data collection phase of the study (Mills & Gay, 2019). The researcher utilized two ways to analyze data, including the Cronbach's Alpha test and the Pearson r test.

The researcher downloaded the information from the survey in Survey Monkey and extracted specific details into a report. The following steps included transferring the

response data. The next steps included creating a report containing the responses' data and transmitting the information into a Microsoft Excel spreadsheet before running it through IBM SPSS. The utilization of Survey Monkey allowed for better organization of the research data into a spreadsheet that aided in more efficient data analysis with less probability of errors (Creswell & Creswell, 2018).

The researcher's next step involved preparing the codebook to translate the data collected into a usable form to be analyzed using the IBM SPSS software (Pallant, 2020). This step consists of assigning particular codes to each item and summarizing the actions taken to translate the information into a format readable by the IBM SPSS program. The researcher then coded the data from the Survey Monkey report by creating a specific code for each item and recording it on a legend. The researcher assigned a numerical number for each item to make the demographic information numerical and consistent with a quantitative study.

Before running the statistical reports, the researcher first ran the Cronbach's alpha test. Researchers use the Cronbach's Alpha test to prove the internal consistency and reliability of the instruments used (Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Mills & Gay, 2019). This test shows that the instrument's items are consistent and measure the same construct (Mills & Gay, 2019). Reliability identifies an instrument's dependability (Roberts & Hyatt, 2019). Validity shows that it genuinely measures what it should measure (Creswell & Creswell, 2018). The instruments used have been used in other studies and proven reliable and valid (Downs & Hazen, 1977; Gipson, 2017 (WIS); Humel, 2019; Yang et al., 2018).

The researcher then used the Pearson r test to test the strength of the examined relationships by computing a correlation coefficient (Mills & Gay, 2019). Mills and Gay (2019) state that the Pearson r test is the most preferred test for correlation coefficient because it consistently shows the most accurate coefficient. Because the Pearson r test provides a correlational coefficient that measures relationships between two variables, it was determined to be the best option to show how supervisory support, communication satisfaction, and the length of time worked remotely individually relate to workplace isolation.

Research question one was **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and supervisory support?** To answer research question one, the researcher used the workplace isolation scale and the supervisory support scale. After data collection, the researcher then prepared the data collected from the survey for analysis. The researcher then converted the individual items into two scores representing the two constructs. For this question, the researcher used the Pearson r test as the analytical test to measure the relationship between the two variables, workplace isolation and supervisory support.

Research question two was **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction?** To answer research question two, the researcher used the workplace isolation scale and the communication satisfaction questionnaire. After data collection, the researcher then prepared the data collected from the survey for analysis. The researcher then converted the individual items into two scores representing the two constructs. For this question, the researcher used the

Pearson r test as the analytical test to measure the relationship between the two variables, workplace isolation, and communication satisfaction.

Research question three was **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely?** To answer research question three the researcher used the workplace isolation scale and question six on the demographic questionnaire. After data collection, the researcher then prepared the data collected from the survey for analysis. The researcher then converted the individual items into two scores representing the two constructs. For this question, the researcher used the Pearson r test as the analytical test to measure the relationship between the two variables, workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely.

Conclusion

In summary, this chapter discussed the identified problem, the research design utilized, information regarding the participants, the instrumentation used, data collection procedures, and analytical methods. The researcher employed the quantitative correlational design to answer the research questions. The next chapter, Chapter IV, provides a complete analysis of the study's findings, conclusions, limitations, and recommendations. This final chapter is the pinnacle of this study because it explains if the study addressed the problem identified in the first chapter and the outcome of the research questions (Roberts & Hyatt, 2019).

CHAPTER IV

FINDINGS AND CONCLUSIONS

Introduction

Remote working is not a new phenomenon, but its use has increased as a viable option for workers that want flexibility in their working environment and schedule. While this option may offer some freedom in some areas, it lacks in others. A significant component of work life is human interaction. People need other people (Jurblum et al., 2020). When human contact diminishes, it can contribute to feeling isolated and disconnected from others. In the workplace, workers sometimes lack physical and emotional connection with others, causing them to feel left out and not supported or acknowledged by others, which is called workplace isolation (Marshall et al., 2007; Orhan et al., 2016). In a remote working situation, the separation of the workplace from the main office or building causes workers not to have physical contact with anyone from their office.

Various studies have looked at remote working in the context of different variables, such as its impact on productivity, employee engagement, work satisfaction, productivity, and social connectedness (Aczel et al., 2021; Johnston & Shahani, 2020; Moretti et al., 2020). This study looked at it from a different angle. As remote work options become more utilized, it will be crucial to understand the things that impact its

benefits. As employers realize the demand employees want when working remotely, the opportunities and benefits must be discussed and understood for the employer to be competitive. Awareness of certain factors contributing to negative feelings, such as workplace isolation, is crucial. Additionally, knowing the factors contributing to workplace isolation is vital to circumvent workplace isolation or mitigate its effects.

The purpose of this study includes discovering if relationships exist among remote workers experiencing workplace isolation and support from their supervisor based on the time they have worked remotely. The researcher employed a quantitative research method to explore this topic. Quantitative research involves the analysis of numeric data to help identify, predict, or describe an area of concern (Mills & Gay, 2019). Quantitative research design includes correlational and predictive (Creswell & Creswell, 2018). While both look at relationships among variables, the predictive adds the element of predicting an outcome (Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Mills & Gay, 2019). In quantitative research, determining relationships or correlations among the variables requires using a correlational design (Mills & Gay, 2019). The researcher chose correlational relational because the focus was on the relationships between the variables.

The researcher collected data in only one phase. The collected data from the survey targeted remote workers at least eighteen years old and living in the United States. The data collection occurred through responses generalized from a survey conducted through Survey Monkey, a digital survey platform that often helps users create and distribute surveys. Potential participants received an electronic invitation that included a description of the process for completing the survey and a link to go directly to it. The invitation instructed participants to forward the survey to anyone meeting the criteria they

felt would also be interested in completing it, called the snowball method (Mills & Gay, 2019).

This chapter reports the presence of workplace isolation among remote workers, the implications of the factors contributing to it, and the specific variables outlined in this study. It will also report the survey's findings, limitations associated with data collection, recommendations for future studies, and the researcher's closing comments and conclusions. The research questions used to determine the relationships among the identified variables were:

1. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and supervisory support?
2. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction?
3. What was the relationship between workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely?

Data Assurance

In research, the researcher's goal is to conduct a valid and reliable study (Mills & Gay, 2019). However, there may be threats to validity that may or may not be within the researcher's control. Assuring the validity and reliability of the instruments is vital. On the other hand, determining if the sample size was valid is essential to ensuring that the participants adequately represented the intended audience or population of the study. The researcher ran descriptive statistics through SPSS to determine the overall makeup of the participants in the study.

This study presented various threats to both internal and external validity. Internal validity relates to what capacity the differences of the dependent variable attribute to manipulating the independent variable (Mills & Gay, 2019). Researchers aim to minimize any threats to internal validity to come to a valid conclusion about how one variable affects the other (Simon & Goes, 2018). Attrition, also called mortality, is a decrease in the number of participants due to participants dropping out of a study (Mills & Gay, 2019). Attrition was an internal validity threat identified in this study based on the caveat that the data used came from participants who completed the survey. Because some participants may have only completed a portion of the survey, their responses could not count, contributing to attrition. Likewise, participants may think the survey was too long and decided not to complete it. To mitigate the possibility of this internal threat to validity, the researcher included an introduction to the survey to explain to participants that they are required to complete the survey entirely before submitting it. This invitation also explained the importance of completing all the questions on the survey.

External validity is how generalizable the study's results are to other populations outside of the one studied (Mills & Gay, 2019). It addresses how the study can relate to people and settings not used in the research (Simon & Goes, 2018). Time constraints were one threat to external validity associated with this study, mainly when participants felt they did not have enough time to complete a lengthy survey with multiple sections and a significant number of questions. To mitigate the impact of this threat to external validity, the researcher included an explanation and disclaimer in the invitation email that the survey may take up to 30 minutes to complete, informing participants of the time

commitment involved in their participation. Providing this explanation allows them to plan accordingly and set aside enough time to take the survey.

Reliability and generalizability are two additional aspects addressed in this study. Reliability is a test consistently measuring what the researcher intended to measure (Mills & Gay, 2019). Mitigating reliability concerns requires all the instruments used to collect data in various studies to show reliability (Munir, 2018; Orhan et al., 2016). To ensure generalizability, the researcher included a pre-participation questionnaire that helped identify participants representing the population examined. The study aimed to have at least 30 participants but anticipated more. An increased number of participants helps prove generalizability wherein the results of the individuals fit the description and criteria thought to represent the population.

To ensure the reliability and validity of each instrument, the researcher used the SPSS software to run a Cronbach Alpha for each of them. Researchers often use the Cronbach Alpha test for internal reliability and consistency (Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Simon & Goes, 2018). It looks at each instrument's items to determine if they are related and measures the same thing (Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Mills & Gay, 2019; Simon & Goes, 2018). The results indicated each instrument to be reliable and valid. Table 1 shows the outcome of the Cronbach Alpha test results for each of the instruments used in this study, including the workplace isolation scale (WIS), supervisory support scale (SSS), and the communication satisfaction questionnaire (CSQ).

Table 1*Cronbach's Alpha Summary*

Instrument	Cronbach's Alpha	Number of Items
WIS	0.901	10
SSS	0.940	9
CSQ	0.984	40

WIS-Workplace Isolation Scale

SSS- Supervisory Support Scale

CSQ- Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire

Findings

In general, the research findings were very comprehensive. The findings section seemed to be consistent with a summary or conclusion. The findings explained the most notable things discovered due to the study, which explored how supervisory support, communication satisfaction, and length of time correlated with workplace isolation. The research findings seem to be an essential part of explaining the overall outcome of the study. The researcher had to prepare the data for analysis to determine the results. The following sections will describe the areas of analysis and the process involved in conducting the analyses. This section will first review the participant demographics to describe the makeup and characteristics of the target population and the participants' final sample. Finally, the results from each research question are thoroughly analyzed and interpreted.

Participant Demographics

Also, essential to determining validity is identifying if the sample adequately represented the study's target population and intended audience. Demographic data helped to identify and describe the population based on responsiveness (Salkind & Frey,

2020). Data collected included age, gender, job role, and the number of years worked remotely.

Descriptive statistics help to describe the critical characteristics of the sample representing the population (Salkind & Frey, 2020; Simon & Goes, 2018). The researcher ran data through the SPSS statistics software to determine the overall makeup of the participants in this study. Descriptive statistics help to describe a set of data more thoroughly (Mills & Gay, 2019; Simon & Goes, 2018). By collecting demographic information, the researcher can estimate the entire population based on a smaller sample (Coppock & McClellan, 2019). The researcher collected specific information from each participant to get an idea of their characteristics that further describe or explain why they feel the way they do. The analysis of participants by their demographic characteristics helps predict certain behaviors based on those characteristics by comparing the entire group (Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Mills & Gay, 2019).

In the SPSS program, the type of data analyzed determines the specific test to run. The researcher used the SPSS software program to run a descriptive statistics analysis for gender and job role. The data reported for gender and job role are considered nominal. Nominal or categorical data categorizes data into specific groups. For nominal data running a frequency analysis is the best option (Salkind & Frey, 2020). Table 2 provides an analysis of the participants by gender and job role.

Table 2
Demographics of Participants

Variable	<i>n</i>	%
Gender		
Female	190	83
Male	22	9.6
No Answer	17	7.4
Job Role		
Non-supervisory	133	58.1
Supervisory	81	35.4
No Answer	15	6.6

To further describe the participant group, the researcher analyzed data by age. The targeted population included individuals at least eighteen years old. The survey asked the participants to write the number for their age. To determine descriptive statistics for numeric data, the researcher ran descriptive statistics. Numeric data most often used in quantitative research are those items consisting of actual numbers (Mills & Gay, 2019). In the survey, the participants' ages are considered numeric data. To analyze age, the researcher ran a descriptive analysis of the participant demographics. Since the responses were actual numbers, it is considered numeric. To get the descriptive statistics for the numeric demographics, the researcher ran a descriptive statistics analysis in SPSS. Based on the output of the SPSS calculation for age, the mean age was 47.90 years old, with a standard deviation of 9.98. The ages ranged from 21 years old to 78 years old.

The researcher also collected information from participants that could be interesting and indicate trends in the labor industry. Question seven of the demographic questionnaire asked participants if they began working remotely due to the COVID-19 pandemic. This information could help explain the makeup of the participants and the factors that may influence their perceptions. The impact of the pandemic on this

workforce option is a legitimate concern. The prevalence of remote working has increased in recent years but has risen significantly since the COVID-19 pandemic began (Allen et al., 2021; Brynjolfsson et al., 2020; Pozen & Samuel, 2021). Table 3 shows participants' responses to question seven on the demographic questionnaire.

Table 3

Remote Work Began with COVID

	<i>n</i>	<i>%</i>
Yes	150	65.5
No	63	27.5
No Answer	16	7
Total	229	100.0

Research Question #1

The first research question was, **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and supervisory support?** The instrument used to determine a relationship between these two variables were the workplace isolation scale and the supervisory support scale. The instrument used to measure respondent's perception of workplace isolation was the workplace isolation scale developed by Marshall et al. (2007). It is a ten-item scale revised from the original 65-item scale (Marshall et al., 2007). The workplace isolation scale has been used in other studies and has shown to be consistently reliable (Munir, 2018; Orhan et al., 2016).

The researcher used the supervisory support scale to measure the perception of supervisory support (Greenhaus et al., 1990). Other studies have examined how supervisory control, trust, and leadership style impact workplace and social isolation

(Gallatin, 2018; Munir, 2018). The other aspects examined are essential to understanding how those elements impact workplace isolation. The impact of its relationship with the level of support employees perceive they are receiving from their supervisors. This study fills the gap in the literature by examining how other factors not previously studied influence workplace isolation.

The Pearson r correlation test is a parametric test that measures relationships between variables based on similarities and differences among the sample, given that the sample is large enough to represent the population (Salkind & Frey, 2020). A Pearson r correlation was run to analyze the relationship between workplace isolation ($M = 52.29$, $SD = 12.03$) and supervisory support ($M = 22.34$, $SD = 10.11$), showing a significant relationship between the variables that was moderate and negative, $r(185) = .436$, $p < .001$. These results mean that as supervisory support decreases, workplace isolation increases. On the other hand, as workplace isolation increases, supervisory support decreases.

Supervisors could take this information and learn from it. Supervisors must remember that supervisory support is a valuable asset for an organization as it helps to encourage work engagement and career satisfaction (Yang et al., 2018). Leaders in organizations may use the results of this study to develop professional development and training programs for current and potential supervisors. Organizations, supervisors, leaders, and employees in a remote environment can all benefit from the results of this study and the identification of this strong relationship between supervisory support and workplace isolation.

Research Question #2

The second research question was, **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction?** To identify a relationship between the two variables of workplace isolation and communication satisfaction, the researcher used a Pearson r correlation test. Workplace isolation was measured using the workplace isolation scale. Communication satisfaction was measured using the communication satisfaction scale. Other studies have focused on communication satisfaction (Baker, 2021; Humel, 2019; Reynolds, 2022). For example, a recent study examined how employees' years of service influence their communication satisfaction scores (Reynolds, 2022).

A Pearson r correlation was run to determine the relationship between workplace isolation ($M = 52.29$, $SD = 12.03$) and communication satisfaction ($M = 116.16$, $SD = 47.30$). The relationship was strong, negative, and significant, $r(169) = .591$, $p < .001$. So as one goes up, the other goes down. As communication satisfaction increases, workplace isolation decreases. As it increases, communication satisfaction decreases.

The communication satisfaction questionnaire has eight subsets to identify specific domains of communication satisfaction, including corporate perspective (CP), personal feedback (PF), organizational integration (OI), relation with supervisor (SUP), communication climate (CC), horizontal communication (HC), media quality (MQ), and relation with subordinates (SUB). The researcher used the overall communication satisfaction score to answer research question two. Each subset's results are in Table 4.

Table 4*Communication Satisfaction Subsets*

Variable	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
CP	15.22	6.5
PF	17.08	7.47
OI	14.73	6.35
SUP	14.84	7.21
CC	16.91	7.49
HC	15.26	6.51
MQ	15.40	6.98
SUB	13.52	6.6

Range Legend:

5-8 = Very Satisfied

9-13= Satisfied

14-19= Somewhat Satisfied

20-21= Indifferent

22-26= Somewhat Dissatisfied

27-31= Dissatisfied

32-35= Very Dissatisfied

Based on the positive and significant relationship between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction, organizations with remote workers can plan to create a robust communication process that keeps employees informed consistently. By identifying this relationship, leaders in organizations offering remote work can focus on improving communication with this workforce segment. Increased communication leads to increased trust, engagement, and loyalty (Burkus, 2021; Citrin & Derosa, 2021; Eikenberry & Turmel, 2018).

Research Question #3

The third research question was, **what was the relationship between workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely?** The variables in this research question were workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely. As mentioned, workplace isolation was measured using the workplace isolation scale, which measures perceptions of workplace isolation. The other variable, the length of time worked remotely, was measured by capturing participants' responses to question eight of the demographic question, which asks how long have you worked remotely? The researcher hoped to find a correlation between the two variables.

The researcher used a Pearson r correlation test to identify if a relationship existed. Workplace isolation ($M = 52.29$, $SD = 12.03$) and the length of time worked remotely ($M = 2.86$, $SD = 3.26$) was analyzed using a Pearson r correlation, which showed no significant relationship between these variables, $r(201) = .032$. This revelation could prove helpful to leaders in organizations offering remote work options. It can reassure them that their seasoned employees with longevity on the job may not feel the impact of workplace isolation based on the number of years they have worked for the organization. No additional interventions or measures will need to occur based on tenure, so employers can focus their efforts proportionately among all employees.

The results of this Pearson r correlation showing no relationship between the two variables is helpful information for leaders managing remote workers. They can keep this information in mind and not utilize resources to focus on specific groups based on how long they have worked remotely. They can focus their attention on other factors shown to

impact workplace isolation. By doing this, they do not waste time or energy addressing something that does not directly impact remote workers.

Summary of the Findings

This study aimed to identify potential relationships between workplace isolation and supervisory support, communication satisfaction, and the length of time worked remotely. Based on the findings from the statistical analysis, a positive, significant relationship existed between workplace isolation and supervisory support and communication satisfaction, respectively. In general, the research findings were very comprehensive. The findings section seemed to be consistent with a summary or conclusion. The results served as an explanation of the most notable things discovered because of the study. The research findings seem to be an essential part of explaining the overall outcome of the study. This findings section reviewed the study's results after doing analyses using inferential and descriptive statistics. Inferential statistics identify correlations between the variables, while descriptive statistics further describe the characteristics of those relationships (Salkind & Frey, 2020).

The findings of this study identified several significant relationships. While two of the relationships were significant, the other, exploring a relationship between workplace isolation and the length of time worked remotely, was not, $r(201) = .032$. There was a strong relationship between workplace isolation and supervisory support. This information is vital for remote workers, organizations offering remote working options, and supervisors and managers in those organizations.

The study also identified a relationship between workplace isolation and communication satisfaction. This relationship demonstrates that when workers feel that

supervisors are not adequately communicating with them, they have a higher probability of experiencing workplace isolation. The relationship is negative, showing an indirect correlation, which means that the variables go in the opposite direction, and as one variable goes up, the other does not (Salkind & Frey, 2020). As supervisory support increases, workplace isolation decreases.

The findings identified two significant relationships related to research questions one and two. Both supervisory support and communication satisfaction had a negative significant relationship with workplace isolation. The negative relationships indicate that when remote workers feel supported by their supervisor and satisfied with the communication they receive, they feel less workplace isolation.

The researcher further analyzed the data to identify if there was a relationship between supervisory support and communication satisfaction. The researcher ran a Pearson r correlation test, which showed a strong, positive, relationship between supervisory support ($M = 22.34$, $SD = 10.11$) and communication satisfaction ($M = 116.16$, $SD = 37.31$), $r(169) = .616$, $p < .001$. These positive results mean that as one goes up, so does the other. In terms of this study, when remote workers feel satisfied with supervisory support, they also feel satisfied with communication. So, when supervisors consistently provide the level of support desired by these employees and communicate effectively and frequently, they experience fewer feelings of workplace isolation.

A valid survey is crucial because the researcher wants to know if their research can give them the results they anticipate seeing in the target population (Sharpe et al., 2019). Overall, the analysis of the data collected from the survey indicates that workplace isolation is present among remote workers, and it is significantly influenced by how

employees perceive their supervisors are supporting them. The analysis also shows that communication satisfaction affects workplace isolation, as indicated by the significant relationship between the two variables.

This study helped address the gap of how various factors influence the incidences of workplace isolation, specifically supervisory support, communication satisfaction, and the length of time worked remotely. The results directly correlate with workplace isolation, supervisory support, and communication satisfaction. However, there was no identifiable relationship between how long a remote worker has worked remotely and workplace isolation. The researcher noted implications within this study; however, the researcher is confident that the information is valid. The participants were consistent with the targeted group the researcher intended. Therefore, the researcher agrees that it generalizes the targeted population. Additionally, the instruments were both valid and reliable.

The gap in the literature included the lack of specific studies addressing how workplace isolation relates to other variables that remote workers may experience. Bentein et al. (2017) conducted a study to look at workplace isolation and how it can impact work engagement. Orhan et al. (2016) conducted another study examining the relationship between workplace isolation and work outcomes. Supervisory support was the heart of a study that examined how it influenced work engagement and career outcomes (Yang et al., 2018). The study identified that the more supervisory support increased, the more work engagement and career satisfaction increased. Remote working is a particular setting that can offer many benefits making it an attractive option to many employees and organizations (Aczel et al., 2021; Johnston & Shahani, 2020; Marica,

2018; Moretti et al., 2020; Olsen et al., 2018; Toscano & Zappala, 2020). However, there are drawbacks associated with it such as workplace isolation (Choudhury et al., 2020; Kupa, 2020; Nolan, 2020; Timsal & Awais, 2016). While the previous studies have identified these issues as being relevant, they have not specifically examined the relationships between workplace isolation, supervisory support, communication satisfaction, and the length of time worked remotely.

The gap in the literature included the lack of specific studies addressing how workplace isolation relates to other variables that remote workers may experience. The benefit of determining these relationships is to bring awareness and attention to leaders in organizations that allow employees to work remotely. By understanding the relationships between the variables included in this study, employers and employees can benefit by knowing what to improve to avoid feelings of workplace isolation. Workplace isolation often decreases morale, productivity, and engagement (Bentein et al., 2017; Marshall et al., 2007). The goal of increasing support and communication is to reduce workplace isolation incidents. If organizations do not identify these warning signs indicating these areas are insufficient, they increase the risk of employees feeling disconnected from the organization and their co-workers. An increased risk of workplace isolation could be detrimental to the success of the organization and its remote working option.

Remote working will continue to be a work option for many. Due to the recent surge in its use, many employees that may not have been interested in working remotely have grown accustomed to it and may be reluctant to return to the office. Also, because many organizations have seen the cost savings associated with remote work, such as the lower overhead costs of maintaining a building, mileage reimbursement, and reduced

utility costs, there will be many opportunities for employees interested in working remotely. One of the questions included in the survey for this study asked, do you intend to return to work? Table 5 illustrates how participants felt about returning to working in a centralized physical office. It shows that it was split almost down the middle on employees intending to return to the office.

Table 5

Intention to Return to Work in Office

	<i>n</i>	<i>%</i>
No	109	47.6
Yes	105	45.9
No Answer	14	6.6

Limitations

The researcher started the study amid a global pandemic and may have reaped the benefit of an increased pool of participants. The onset of the pandemic increased the number of people working remotely, therefore increasing the researcher's likelihood of obtaining a larger sample size. However, although it may offer some benefits, it may have increased the employee's likelihood of feeling isolated, especially if forced to work from home due to the social distancing requirements instituted because of the need for social distancing. Social distancing often causes feelings of social isolation and the perception of workplace isolation (Orhan et al., 2016). The researcher provided clear instructions with the survey to clear up any ambiguity. The demographic portion of the survey asked participants, *did you start working remotely due to the COVID-19 pandemic?* The responses revealed that 66% of participants stated that they began working remotely due to the COVID-19 pandemic.

The researcher realized during and after the study that there were opportunities for improving efficiency. First, there were several opportunities with the actual survey. Participants skipped several questions. After studying the missed questions, the researcher concluded several things. Several questions did not have alternative choices for answers. For instance, the gender question only had two options, male or female. The researcher did not account for the various ways individuals identify sexually. The survey did not include alternative choices. There were questions in the demographic questionnaire that were yes or no. However, there was no choice for either not applicable or don't know. Even though the focus of the study was not on race, it did not ask any questions regarding race. It was not a criterion for participation in the study; it could be beneficial when describing the participants and could further identify additional correlations.

The researcher utilized Survey Monkey as the survey tool. This tool is sometimes biased because even though popular web-based surveys are easy to use and take, they can be biased (Simon & Goes, 2018). They are usually free and offer flexibility in how the survey link goes out; however, using this tool can restrict the study participants (Simon & Goes, 2018). Online surveys can reach many more potential respondents than mail or paper surveys; it could result in incomplete responses if the participant experiences internet issues while taking the survey (Simon & Goes, 2018). Nonresponse bias is a concern in online services because it could prevent possible participants due to lack of access to the internet (Mlikotic et al., 2016). Using a web-based survey could also limit responses from potential participants based on their age or technological savvy (Mlikotic et al., 2016). The purpose of collecting demographic questions in research surveys is to

answer research questions, describe the sample, help subsequent researchers replicate the study findings, and gain more information about the sample to determine if it genuinely generalized the targeted population (Hughes et al., 2016). In this study, some demographic information helped answer research questions, while the others helped describe the sample. Also, there may be an issue with participants trying to take the survey more than once (Simon & Goes, 2018). One way to avoid multiple responses is to allow a password for participation or link-only access (Simon & Goes, 2018).

To conserve time, the researcher created the survey and sent it out to potential respondents without first piloting it to a smaller group. Conducting pilot studies help to test out the survey before sending it out to the larger group where the data needed for the survey are collected. A pilot test helps the researcher identify if the survey method is solid and valid (Sharpe et al., 2019). Failing to send the survey out to a pilot group before sending out the official survey first resulted in an error on one of the questions. The question was noticed within the first ten survey completions and immediately corrected. Making the survey too long is a common mistake related to a survey's design. The researcher chose three instruments to collect data that could help identify relationships between the variables; however, the inclusion of the three instruments and a demographic questionnaire made for a very lengthy survey. The researcher noticed the effects of the long survey in the number of incomplete surveys and responses missing in the last portion of the survey, which included the instrument with the most questions. Even though the researcher gave participants an estimated time of completion in the survey invitation and asked for completion of the entire survey, the length of the survey may have contributed to participants not completing it.

Often survey responsiveness is associated with a good quality survey by correlating survey response with quality results (Dillman et al., 2014). Responsiveness is another potential issue with surveys. It is unrealistic to think that everyone sent an invitation will participate (Sharpe et al., 2019). Online surveys through programs such as Survey Monkey will distribute the survey to many more people than other methods; however, it could result in low response rates, contributing to biases in the results (Sharpe et al., 2019).

In data analysis, the researcher ran into issues with the limitation of needing to combine two columns of data from demographic question number eight to give the total time worked remotely. The survey called for the time worked remotely with special instruction to list years or if less than a year, enter months. When preparing the survey results for analysis the researcher had to convert the months into a fraction of a year to consolidate the years and months into one number and one column of data to make it easier to analyze. An alternative answer option could have been to enter the number of years worked remotely and give instructions to put zero if it was less than a year. Also, many of the questions on the survey focused on remote workers working for an organization or company. However, it was open to any remote worker. However, many individuals that work remotely are freelance or self-employed, and some of the questions did not fit their situation.

Implications and Recommendations

Improving communication with workers with little to no physical contact with supervisors and co-workers is vital. Regular communication with remote workers demonstrates to these employees that they are indeed a part of the organization. It helps

them to realize that the team is not held within the confines of four walls but can extend to any geographical area. Proactively reminding supervisors to communicate more often helps increase trust among employees. Supervisors' attentiveness in conversations with employees offers an additional trust-building factor.

Trust is a significant component that influences an employee's job performance (Jude & Kumar, 2016; Kaplan et al., 2018). It also increases the sense of unity within the organization and does not show possible favoritism to employees that work within the same building as the leaders. It dispels the adage of out of sight, out of mind and replaces it with a sense of unity and a one-team, multiple-location approach. By understanding the variables' relationships, employers and employees can benefit by knowing what to work on to avoid feelings of isolation.

This study specifically used a sample of remote workers working in the United States or U. S. territories. One recommendation is to expand the population to include remote workers outside the United States and its territories. Expanding the population will gain a more comprehensive perspective of remote workers worldwide.

Another recommendation is to examine how workplace isolation, the lack of supervisory support, and dissatisfaction contribute to turnover. This study used a quantitative research design with a correlational approach. A qualitative or mixed-model design can be the design used in future studies. Another recommendation is to continue this study by adding a qualitative aspect, making it a mixed-model design. Once the researcher collects the quantitative data from the surveys, selecting a sample of participants to participate in interviews to gain additional insight that may contribute to the body of knowledge.

Conclusion

Remote working, also known as telecommuting, is a viable option for many workers to have an alternative working arrangement to accommodate the needs of the organizations where they are employed. Whether it occurs as an option to the traditional work setting, as an alternative to keep up with the requirements of today's workers wanting more flexibility, or a product of the COVID-19 pandemic and the need to social distance to slow the spread of infection, it is here to stay and the new standard of the workplace (Sahai et al., 2020). While it offers many benefits, such as increased flexibility, no commute, and additional opportunities to spend time with family due to the reductions of the previously stated benefits, it offers several challenges (Choudhury, 2020; Marica, 2018; Nolan, 2020; Sahai et al., 2020; Toscano & Zappala, 2020). As remote working becomes more prevalent, organizations must focus on identifying how to make necessary accommodations so that remote workers do not feel isolated (Choudhury, 2020; Sahai et al., 2020).

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APPENDIX A

Remote Worker Survey

Remote Worker Survey (Includes consent, demographic questionnaire, the Workplace Isolation Scale, Supervisory Support Scale, and Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire)

Q1. Consent to Participate: By clicking “yes” below and completing the survey, I am authorizing my consent to participate in this study. I also hereby acknowledge that: 1. I have read and understand the above description of the study. 2. I understand that if I participate, I may withdraw at any time without penalty. Should you have any questions/concerns about your rights as a research participant, please contact TNU’s Institutional Review Board at IRB@trevecca.edu. Yvette Jones, Doctoral Candidate, YAJones@trevecca.edu. Do you agree to participate in this study?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Demographic Questionnaire (Gallatin, 2018)

Q2. Gender

☐ Male

☐ Female

Q3. Do you work in the United States or U.S. Territories?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Q4. Are you at least 18 years old?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Q5. Age ____

Q6. Role with the company:

☐ Supervisory role

☐ Non-supervisory role

Q7. Did you start working remotely due to the COVID-19 pandemic?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Q8. Do you intend to go back to working in the office?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Q9. Length of time you have worked remotely. If year or more enter years. If less than a year enter months. ____ years, ____ months

Q10. The number of hours per week you worked remotely. ____

Workplace Isolation Scale (Marshall, et al., 2007)

Please indicate how you perceive isolation from others at work by selecting the appropriate number on the right.	Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Somewhat Disagree	Neither Agree nor Disagree	Somewhat Agree	Agree	Strongly Agree
Q11 I have friends available to me at work.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q12 I have one or more co-workers available whom I can depend on when I have a problem.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q13 I have co-workers available whom I can depend on when I have a problem.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q14 I have enough people available at work with whom I can talk about my job.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q15 I have people around me at work.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q16 I am well integrated with the department/company where I work.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q17 I am kept in the loop regarding company social events/functions.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q18 I am part of the company network.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q19 Upper management knows about my achievements.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q20 My supervisor communicates my achievements to upper management.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Supervisory Support Scale (Greenhaus et al., 1990)

Please indicate how you perceive the extent to which you receive supervisory support in your job by selecting the appropriate number on the right.	Strongly Agree	Agree to some extent	Uncertain	Disagree to some extent	Strongly Disagree
Q21 My supervisor takes the time to learn about my career goals and aspirations.	1	2	3	4	5
Q22 My supervisor cares about whether or not I achieve my goals.	1	2	3	4	5
Q23 My supervisor keeps me informed about different career opportunities for me in the organization.	1	2	3	4	5
Q24 My supervisor makes sure I get the credit when I accomplish something substantial on the job.	1	2	3	4	5
Q25 My supervisor gives me helpful feedback about my performance.	1	2	3	4	5
Q26 My supervisor gives me helpful advice about improving my performance when I need it.	1	2	3	4	5
Q27 My supervisor supports my attempts to acquire additional training or education to further my career.	1	2	3	4	5
Q28 My supervisor provides assignments that give me the opportunity to develop and strengthen new skills.	1	2	3	4	5
Q29 My supervisor assigns me special projects that increase my visibility in the organization.	1	2	3	4	5

Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire (Downs & Hazen, 1977)

Listed below are several kinds of information often associated with a person's job and/or quality of each kind of information by choosing the appropriate response.	Very Satisfied	Satisfied	Slightly Satisfied	Indifferent	Slightly Satisfied	Dissatisfied	Very Dissatisfied
Q30 Information about my progress in my role within the organization	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q31 Personnel news	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q32 Information about organizational policies and goals	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q33 Information about how my job/role compares with others	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q34 Information about how I am being judged	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q35 Recognition of my efforts	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q36 Information about member groups' policies and goals	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q37 Information about the requirements of my job/role	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q38 Information about government action affecting the organization	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q39 Information about changes in the organization	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q40 Reports on how problems in my	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

job/role are being handled							
Q41 Information about employee/member benefits and pay	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q42 Information about organizational profits and financial standing	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q43 Information about accomplishments and/or failures of the organization	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Please indicate how satisfied you are with the following by choosing the appropriate response.	Very Satisfied	Satisfied	Slightly Satisfied	Indifferent	Slightly Dissatisfied	Dissatisfied	Very Dissatisfied
Q44 Extent to which superiors know & understand issues and/or problems faced by subordinates	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q45 Extent to which the organizational communication motivates & stimulates an enthusiasm for meeting its goals	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q46 Extent to which leaders listen and pay attention to me	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q47 Extent to which the people in the organization have a great ability as communicators	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q48 Extent to which leaders offer guidance for solving job/role related problems	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Q49 Extent to which the organization's communication makes me identify with it or feel a vital part of	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q50 Extent to which the organization's publications are interesting and helpful	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q51 Extent to which leaders and/or supervisors trust me	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q52 Extent to which I receive on time the information needed to do my job	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q53 Extent to which conflicts are handled appropriately through proper communication channels	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q54 Extent to which the grapevine is active in our organization	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q55 Extent to which my supervisor/leader is open to ideas	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q56 Extent to which horizontal communication with other employees/members is accurate and free flowing	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q57 Extent to which communication practices are adequate to emergencies	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q58 Extent to which my work group is compatible	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Q59 Extent to which our meetings are well-organized	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q60 Extent to which the amount of supervision given to me is adequate	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q61 Extent to which written directives and reports are clear and concise	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q62 Extent to which the attributes toward communication in the company are healthy	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q63 Extent to which informal communication is active and accurate	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q64 Extent to which the amount of communication in the organization accurate	1	2	3	4	5	6	
Answer the following if you are a manager/supervisor employed with the organization or if you are a leader of a group	Very Satisfied	Satisfied	Slightly Satisfied	Indifferent	Slightly Dissatisfied	Dissatisfied	Very Dissatisfied
Q65 Extent to which my subordinates are responsive to downward directive communication	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q66 Extent to which my subordinates anticipate my needs for information	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q67 Extent to which I do not have a communication overload	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Q68 Extent to which my subordinates are receptive to evaluation suggestions, and criticisms	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Q69 Extent to which my subordinates feel responsible for initiating accurate upward communication	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Appendix B

Approvals to Use Instruments

Approvals to Use Instruments

Workplace Isolation Scale

Doctoral student requesting permission to use the Workplace Isolation Scale

Jones, Yvette A

To:

- gmarshall@rollins.edu <GMARSHALL@Rollins.edu>

Cc:

- yvetteajones@hotmail.com

Thu 9/2/2021 6:57 PM

Good evening Dr. Marshall,

My name is Yvette Jones, and I am a doctoral student at Trevecca Nazarene University. I would like to use your Workplace Isolation Scale in my research and am requesting your permission to use it. Would you allow me to use the Workplace Isolation Scale for my research? Please let me know and thank you in advance.

Sincerely,

Yvette Jones

Greg Marshall <GMARSHALL@Rollins.edu>

To:

- Jones, Yvette A

Cc:

- yvetteajones@hotmail.com;
- j.mulki@northeastern.edu

Fri 9/3/2021 8:59 AM

CAUTION: This email originated from outside of the organization. Do not click links or open attachments unless you recognize the sender and know the content is safe.

Yvette,

Thanks for the note. I have copied in Dr. Jay Mulki at Northeastern University, my coauthor on the work. I want to make sure he gives you his "OK" for the usage.

Best wishes,

Greg Marshall

Mulki, Jay <j.mulki@northeastern.edu>

To:

- Greg Marshall <GMARSHALL@Rollins.edu>;

- Jones, Yvette A

Cc:

- yvetteajones@hotmail.com

Fri 9/3/2021 9:20 AM

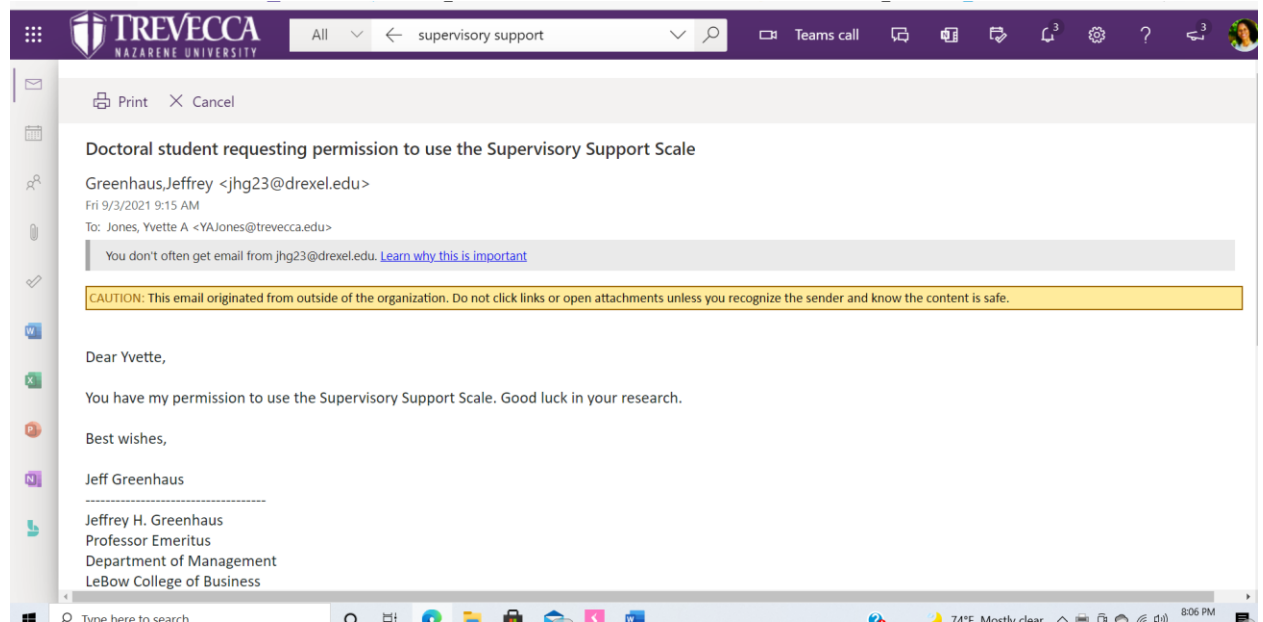
You don't often get email from j.mulki@northeastern.edu. [Learn why this is important](#)

CAUTION: This email originated from outside of the organization. Do not click links or open attachments unless you recognize the sender and know the content is safe.

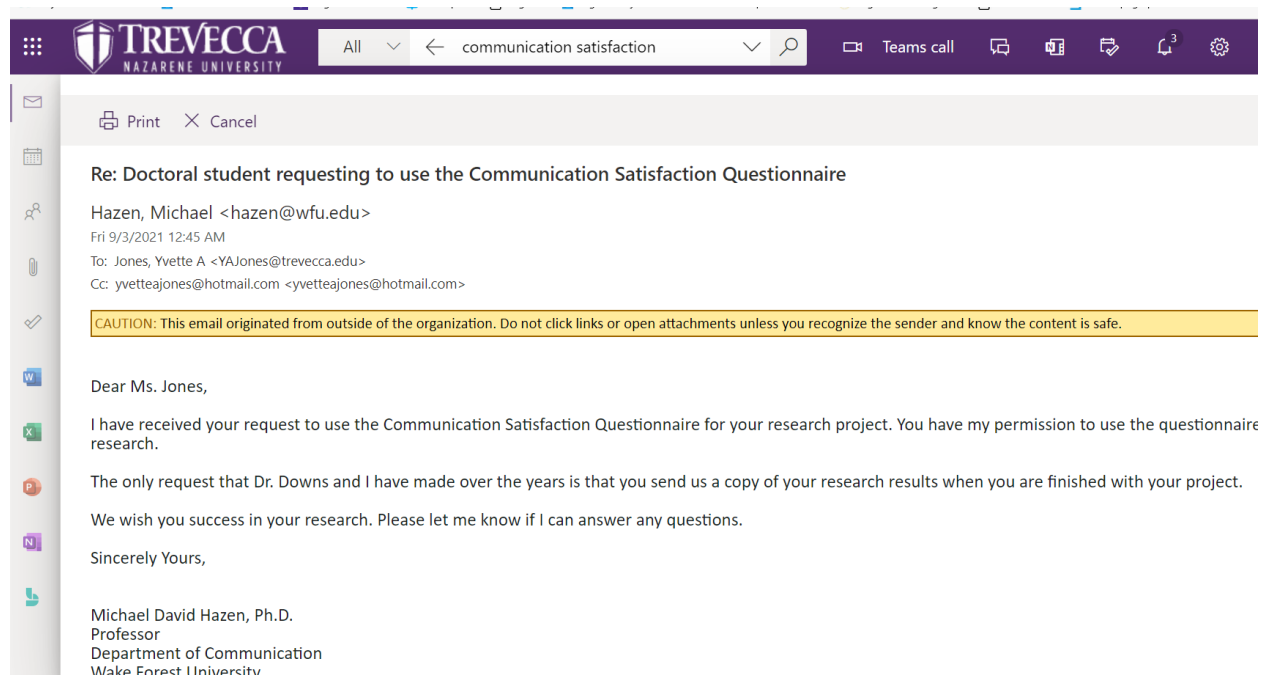
yes.Sure, Yvette.

Sent from my T-Mobile 4G LTE Device

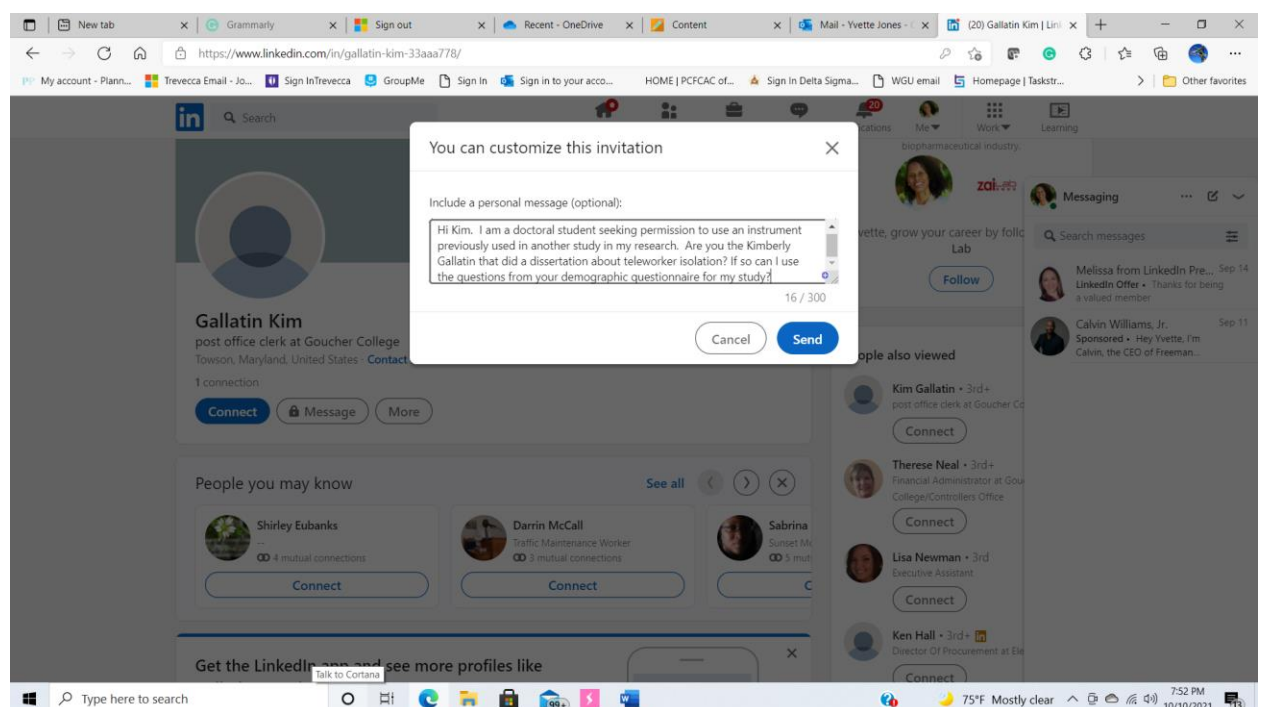
Supervisory Support Scale



Communication Satisfaction Questionnaire



Demographic Questionnaire



Browser tabs: New tab, Grammarly, Sign out, Recent - OneDrive, Content, Mail - Yvette Jones, (20) Kim Gallatin-McC...

Address bar: <https://www.linkedin.com/in/kim-gallatin-mccombs-1638a9a/>

Navigation: My account - Plann..., Trevecca Email - Jo..., Sign In Trevecca, GroupMe, Sign In, Sign in to your acco..., HOME | PCFCAC of..., Sign In Delta Sigma..., WGU email, Homepage | Taskstr...

LinkedIn Header: Search, Home, My Network, Jobs, Messaging, Notifications, Me, Work, Learning

Ad: Online MPH. No GRE Req'd - Join the nation's No. 1 public school of public health. Apply now.

Profile Card: 
Kim Gallatin-McCombs
Executive Office Professional
Gilbert, Arizona, United States · [Contact info](#)
19 connections
[Message](#) [More](#)

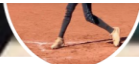
Activity: 19 followers
Posts Kim created, shared, or commented on in the last 90 days are displayed here.
[See all activity](#)

Right Sidebar: **Messaging**
Search messages
Yvette, explore jobs at L'Oréal... your skills [See jobs](#)
Melissa from LinkedIn Pre... Sep 14
Linkedin Offer · Thanks for being a valued member
Calvin Williams, Jr. Sep 11
Sponsored · Hey Yvette, I'm Calvin, the CEO of Freeman...

People also viewed:
Kimberly McCombs · 3rd+ Chief Strategy Officer (CSO) [Connect](#)
Kimberly Niehaus · 3rd+ Finance & Strategy at Open... [Connect](#)
Kimberly Gallatin · 3rd+ Import Coordinator at BDP Inc. [Message](#)

Windows Taskbar: Type here to search, 75°F Mostly clear, 7:54 PM 10/10/2021

Facebook Header: Search Facebook, Home, Watch, Marketplace, Groups, Yvette, 2, 20+

Profile Card: 
Kimberly A Gallatin-McCombs
Posts About Friends Photos Videos Check-Ins More [Add Friend](#) [Message](#)

About
Overview
Work and Education
Places Lived
Contact and Basic Info
Family and Relationships
[Details About Kimberly](#)
Life Events

About Kimberly
 No additional details to show
Name Pronunciation
 No name pronunciation to show
Other Names
 No other names to show
Favorite Quotes
 No favorite quotes to show

Photos

Message Window: Kimberly A Gall...
You're not friends on Facebook
Lives in Phoenix, Arizona
9:13 AM
Good morning Kimberly. I am a doctoral student doing research and I wanted to see if you were the Kimberly Gallatin that did a doctoral dissertation on teleworker isolation. If so I want to get your permission to use some of the questions from your demographic questionnaire. Please let me know. Thanks.

Windows Taskbar: Type here to search, 75°F Cloudy, 9:13 AM 9/21/2021

Appendix C

IRB Approval

Attachments:

- Protocol Approval Notification.pdf

Trevecca Nazarene University IRB

Approval Notification

To: Yvette Jones
From: Jonathan Bartling, IRB Chair
Subject: Protocol #604
Date: 11/04/2021

Thank you for submitting your proposed research project, **Remote work: Factors influencing workplace isolation**, to the Trevecca Nazarene University Institutional Review Board (IRB) for review. Your protocol was approved on **11/04/2021**.

The approval of your study is valid through **11/03/2022**, by which time you must submit an annual report either closing the protocol or requesting permission to continue the protocol for another year. Please submit your report by **10/06/2022** so that the IRB has time to review and approve your report if you wish to continue it for another year.

Please make sure you follow the research procedures as described in the application when you conduct your research. Should you make any modifications to your research project, you must submit an Amendment in Protocol application for IRB approval (located in the Amendments tab at the bottom of your approved application). Additionally, you must notify the IRB of any problems connected with the use of human subjects as they occur.

We wish you the best in your research.

Respectfully:

Jonathan Bartling, Ph.D.
IRB Chair
jdbartling@trevecca.edu

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